

Police shoot dead history-sheeter near Madhavaram

The incident occurred when a police team tried to arrest ‘Thoppai’ Ganesh in connection with a recent dacoity case in Puzhal. He allegedly injured an SI and head constable during his bid to escape

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

Ganesh alias ‘Thoppai’ Ganesh, 38, a history-sheeter, was shot dead by the police near Madhavaram in the early hours of Monday when he reportedly attempted to escape after attacking the police team that had him surrounded. He is said to have been involved in at least 30 criminal cases, including five murders and a dacoity case reported in Puzhal recently. He also had murder, robbery, attempt to murder, Narcotic Drugs and

Psychotropic Substances Act, and Arms Act cases against him, according to the police. Ganesh, also known as Dilli Ganesh, was a resident of BV Colony, Vyasarpadi. He was an A+ category history-sheeter at the MKB Nagar police station. In the early hours of January 30, six unidentified men, wearing masks and caps and armed with knives, forcibly entered the house of Vijayakumar, a businessman and resident of Mahaveer Garden Main Road at East Kavangarai in Puzhal when his wife Vasantha was about to leave for a morning walk. The gang threatened Vasantha, Vijayakumar, their two daughters, and Vijayakumar’s mother at knife-point, tied them up with ropes, assaulted them, and issued death threats. The robbers allegedly then fled with ₹25 lakh in cash kept in the house, and 15 sovereigns of gold jewellery, including diamond-studded gold earrings, gold chains, bangles, bracelets, and rings worn by Vasantha and her family members. The suspects fled the spot in a car. On Monday, the police said that during the course



Taking stock: Additional Commissioner of Police, North, Pravesh Kumar and other officials inspecting the spot where the incident occurred on Monday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

of investigation, the involvement of 10 persons was revealed. Among them, five, including an advocate, were arrested. The remaining five, including Ganesh, were on the run. A special team was formed

under Inspector K. Boopathi Raja of the Thiru. Vi. Ka. Nagar police station to arrest the suspects who were on the run. The police said that on Sunday, they received information that Ganesh was hiding in Manchampakkam area in the Madhavaram police station limits. Early on Monday, the police team found him hiding in a dilapidated building abutting 200 Feet Road from the Madhavaram roundtana, and tried to arrest him. Upon seeing the police, Ganesh tried to escape, and in spite of oral warnings from Mr. Boopathi Ra-

ja, he assaulted Sub-inspector (SI) Subramani and head constable Dinesh Kumar with an *aruval* (sickle), injuring them both. When Ganesh tried to assault them again, Mr. Boopathi Raja fired at Ganesh, but he continued moving towards the police personnel. The police claimed that the Inspector fired the second shot at Ganesh in self-defence. The accused fell after the second shot hit him. Ganesh and the injured police personnel were taken to the Government Stanley Medical College Hospital for treatment. While Ganesh was

declared dead at the hospital, the two policemen are under treatment. On the complaint of Mr. Boopathi Raja, a case was registered at the Madhavaram police station for further investigation. A requisition has been sent for conducting a judicial inquiry into the incident. The investigation officer seized a bag containing six bundles of ganja and two knives after the incident. Additional Commissioner of Police, North, Pravesh Kumar and other officials visited the spot and held a preliminary inquiry. Further investigation is on.

‘Contributions of women in informal sector have been backbone of local economies’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

For decades, women in the informal economy have been the backbone of their families, their communities, and local economies, yet, their contributions have too often remained invisible, Andreas Kappes, secretary general, International Raiffeisen Union (IRU), Germany said. He was speaking at an event ‘From the Margins to the Mainstream: Women’s Economic Empowerment through Cooperatives for Access to International High Tables-Working Women’s Forum (India) (WWF)-Indian Cooperative Network for Women (ICNW)’.

It is a virtual parallel event to the United Nations Commission on the Status

of Women 70th Edition. Mr. Kappes said moving from the margins to the mainstream meant much more than improving incomes. “It means getting recognition, influence, and access to the national and international decision-making arena,” he added. Selvine Stephenson-Grant, deputy programme manager, CARICOM Agricultural and Agro-Industrial Development Directorate of Economic Integration, Innovation and Development, Secretariat, Guyana, said cooperatives enabled women to move from individual survival towards collective strength. Nandini Azad, president of the WWF (India)-ICNW, said lives of women in the informal sector, who had multiple disabilities, con-

tend with low growth and investment, and face social and class oppression, had been transformed. Women workers have mobilised into a mass national and international platform, trained as co-operators, and trade unionists by WWF-ICNW, she added. **Five women honoured** Five women – Jayanthi Prabhakaran, Indira Ravi, Bhuvaneshwari Santho- sam, Eswari, and Baki Jayalakshmi – received the Dr. H.S. Jaya Arunachalam Excellence Awards for 2025-26. Andrea Porro, secretary general, World Farmers Organisation (WFO), Rome, and Daya Goburdhun, associate professor, University of Mauritius, were among those who spoke at the event.

Sun TV should not interfere in obtaining licence to use *Jailer, Coolie* songs in promos: CSK to HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Chennai Super Kings (CSK) Cricket Limited on Monday told the Madras High Court that it would approach music licensing agencies such as Phonographic Performance Limited (PPL) and Novex Communications to obtain licence for using Rajinikanth starrer *Jailer* and *Coolie* songs in its promos but the producer of those movies, Sun TV Network Limited, should not interfere in the process. In an affidavit filed before Justice Senthilkumar Ramamoorthy, CSKCL Managing Director Kasi Viswa-

nathan alias K.S. Viswanathan, 73, said, the cricketing company had been using songs, dialogues, and music from those movies in its promos for quite a few years but Sun TV Network did not raise any objection till March 1, 2026. However, immediately after the receipt of the objection, the company had removed all the copyrighted materials from the promos and informed the movie production house too on the same day, the MD said. The affidavit filed through senior counsel P.S. Raman, stated that CSKCL had also made it inaccessible



The cricketing company said it had removed the copyrighted materials from the promos after the objection was raised.

(CSKCL) hereby undertakes to hereinafter not display, show, upload, exhibit, play, use, any of the sound recordings or musical works including the songs set out in the Schedules to the plaint in the promotions, marketing and/or updates that it prepares in connection with the first defendant, till such time that it acquires the license and/or legal rights to use the same.”

‘No prejudice’ Mr. Viswanath made it clear that he was filing the affidavit without prejudice to the rights of CSKCL to approach the relevant agencies holding the li-

cense for Sun TV Network’s copyrighted work and that the production house should fairly not interfere with such licensing agencies in granting a license. After recording the contents of the undertaking, Justice Ramamoorthy disposed of the interim injunction applications filed by Sun TV Network. He also directed Mr. Ravindran to take instructions from his client by April 6, 2026 as to whether the main copyright infringement suit, seeking damages of ₹1 crore, could also be disposed of in view of the undertaking given by CSKCL.

THE HINDU

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Centre For Railway Information Systems
Channakypuri, New Delhi-110021

Tender Notice
Tender No.: 2025-CRIS-ELECT_14 dt. 17/03/2026. **Subject:** Supply, Installation, Testing, and Commissioning of Maintenance-Free VRLA (Valve Regulated Lead Acid) Hot-Swappable Battery Modules for Eaton Make UPS Systems on a Buy-Back Basis for CRIS Offices. **Tender Closing Date:** 07/04/2026 (15:00 hrs). Tender Documents can be downloaded from Website www.ireps.gov.in. For future modification/ extensions please see www.ireps.gov.in.

CENTRAL RAILWAY
OPEN TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (S&T), 1st Floor, Parcel Office Building, above P.No.14 & 15, Central Railway, Mumbai CST 400 001, for and on behalf of the President of India Invites Open tenders from the reputed contractors. **Tender Notice No.:** CR-BB-SNT-North-2026-23; **Name of work:** Signaling work in connection with proposed construction of pedestrian subway in Kalyan-Igatpur section related to safety fencing at various trespassing locations.; **Approximate Cost:** Rs. 3.21 Crore; **EMD:** Rs. 3,10,600/-; **Date of Opening:** 13.04.2026; **Validity:** 60 Days; **Completion Period:** 12 Months; This tender complies with Public Procurement Policy (Make in India) Order 2017, dated 15.06.2017. Complete details of tenders are available at Central Railway, Official website www.ireps.gov.in the complete tender documents can be downloaded from the website. The complete details of tenders are also available in the ‘Notice Board’ of the Divisional Railway Manager (S&T)’s Office, Mumbai CST. **DE-994**
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POSTGRADUATE INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL EDUCATION & RESEARCH, CHANDIGARH

TENDER NOTICE

Sealed tenders are invited from the manufacturers or their sole authorized distributors/sole agents on the prescribed form for below mention items for two years.

Sr. No.	Name of Drug/Material
1.	Inj. Telicoplanin 400mg/vial
2.	Inj. Aflibercept 40mg/ml
3.	Various Factors for Haemophilia Patients.
4.	Inj. Lignocaine 2%, 50ml vial
5.	Inj. Amphotericin B Liposomal 50mg vial
6.	Tab.Lithium Carbonate 300mg
7.	Rate Contract for Local Purchase of Medicines for two years: This Institute has to make purchase of medicines for patients and PGI staff wherever it deemed fit on emergency basis to cater day-to-day requirements. The Institute intends to enter into Rate Contract for two years with approved licensed Chemist/Druggist holder, who has his shop/service outlet at Chandigarh and can offer maximum discounts on the MRP of medicine/drugs as per terms & conditions contained in the Tender Form.

The Pre-Bid meeting for drugs mentioned at Sr.No.1,2,3,4 and 7 is to be held on 23.03.2026 at 11:30AM in the office of Superintendent Dispensary, Room No. 18A, Ground Floor, Nehru Hospital, PGIMER Chandigarh.

The Tender Form and specification of the products are available on the Institute website www.pgimer.nic.in and eprocure.gov.in. Above mentioned tenders will be received by 12:30 Hours on 15.04.2026 (Due date) in the office of Prof. In-charge (EP), Room No 18-A, Nehru Hospital, Drugs & Dressing Section, Ground Floor, PGIMER, Chandigarh and will be opened at 02.00 PM on the same date at Committee Room attached to the office of Medical Superintendent, Nehru Hospital, PGIMER Chandigarh. **PGI/RC/Advt./2026/HR-000181**

Officer In-charge (HPD), Proc. Drugs & Dressing

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NOTICE INVITING ELECTRONIC TENDERS

On behalf of President of India Principal Chief Materials Manager/ PLW/ Patiala invites tenders in electronic form for following items:

S N	Tender No.	Description	Qty.	Tender closing date
1	12251908B	Cap Polyester Cloth	1924 Nos.	06.04.2026

e-Tender Notice No.47 ET/ 2025-26

Tender closing time 15:00 Hrs.

The prospective Tenderers are advised to visit the website <http://www.ireps.gov.in> or www.indianrailways.gov.in for detailed description of items & other terms and conditions of tender document. Please note that Tenderers can submit their quotations only through <http://www.ireps.gov.in>.

Corrigendum to e-Tender Notice No. 44 ET/2025-26
Closing date of Tender No.11265037 may be read as 19.03.2026. **879/2026**

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BRIEF TENDER NOTIFICATION (Through KPP portal)

BESCOM invites tender for the following Enquiry/Indent No.: **BESCOM/2025-26/EL/WORK_INDENT1062**. Preventive and Breakdown maintenance of all makes of RMUs of all combination of both DAS and Non DAS RMUs in Davanagere Division area of BESCOM for a period of one year under Total Turnkey Basis.

For the above Works: Bid documents available from **17-03-2026**. Last Date for submission is **15-04-2026 at 17:00** hrs. Opening of Bid Document is **16-04-2026 at 17:15** hrs.

The Tenders can be obtained through KPP portal website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>. Aspiring bidders need to register on KPP portal. Further Bidders can take assistance with KPPP help desk contact numbers (080-46010000, 080-68948777) or email at support@eprocelpdesk.com. Further details can be obtained from the office of the undersigned.

Sd/-
Chief General Manager(Elc.,) Procurement, BESCOM

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NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY **CORRIGENDUM**

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) FOR DEVELOPMENT OF A 1000-LOCOMOTIVE CAPACITY FREIGHT ELECTRIC LOCOMOTIVE MAINTENANCE SHED UNDER PPP MODE

With reference to the earlier published notice inviting Expression of Interest (EOI) for ‘Design, Engineering, Procurement, Construction, Commissioning, Operation and Maintenance of a 1000-locomotive capacity Freight Electric Locomotive Maintenance Shed under PPP mode’ in **North Western Railway**, the following **amendments** are hereby notified for information of all interested applicants / developers / OEMs:

1. Certain amendments have been made in the original EOI regarding the purpose of EOI, scope of EOI, EOI schedule, instructions to the developer, eligibility criteria, rights of NWR, evaluation process, etc. Amended EOI document for development of a 1000-loco capacity Electric Locomotive Maintenance Shed at Phulera in Jaipur division under the DBFOT PPP model is uploaded on google drive with link given below.
<https://docs.google.com/document/d/1BKQa9TGyGhrwTAwCg2u77ILW5hUnTE7KxM9NAAALB8/edit?tab=t.0>
2. Last Date for Submission of EOI
 - Earlier: 20.03.2026 up to 15:00 hrs
 - Revised: **10.04.2026 up to 15:00 hrs.**Interested applicants are requested to take note of the above amendments and submit their EOI accordingly within the revised timeline.

371-AR/26 **Chief Electrical Loco Engineer**

BENGALURU WEST CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer,
Kengeri Division, Zone-1, RR Nagar Zone,
BBMP Office Building, CA No.3, 1st Main Road, Outer Ring Road,
Kommaghatta Road, Kengeri Upanagara, Bengaluru - 560060.

No: EE/KEN/TEND/08/2025-26 **Date: 16-03-2026**

INVITATION FOR TENDER (IFT) - (SHORT TERM)
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal only)

The Executive Engineer, Kengeri Division, Zone-1, R.R. Nagar Zone, BWCC, Bengaluru invites Tenders from eligible Tenderers for the Construction of Works detailed below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
TWO COVER SYSTEM - (CALL-1)	
1	Construction of Concrete Road & Drains at Herohalli Colony in Ward No. 28. Approximated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 120.09, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 2,40,500/-
2	Improvements of Roads and Drains at Bhoovi Colony, Mariyapanapalya in Ward No. 30, Nagadevanahalli. Approximated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 200.14, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 4,00,500/-
3	Improvements of Roads, Drains and Others Allied Works at SC / ST Colony in Ward No. 26 & 27. Approximated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 120.09, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 2,40,500/-
4	Improvements of Roads and Drains at SC / ST Colony, Ambedkar Nagar and Ulial Upanagara in Ward No. 29. Approximated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 240.17, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 4,80,500/-
5	Improvements of Roads and Drains at Gandhinagara and Mini Gandhinagara Surrounding Area in Ward No. 31, Bundemutt. Approximated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 200.16, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 4,00,500/-
6	Improvements of Roads and Drains at Arundathanagara and Surrounding Area in Ward No. 31, Bundemutt. Approximated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 200.14, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 4,00,500/-

Calendar of Events: 1) The Tender Documents can be downloaded from the GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> from **4.00 PM on 18-03-2026**. 2) Date of Pre Bid Meeting on **23-03-2026 at 3.00 PM in the Office of the Chief Engineer, Ideal Homes, Rajarajeshwarinagara Zone, Bengaluru - 560098**. 3) Last Date and Time for Receipt of Tenders: **01-04-2026 upto 4.00 PM**. 4) Date of Opening of Bids: **02-04-2026 at 4.30 PM**. Further details can be had from the above office.

Sd/- Executive Engineer,
Kengeri Division, Zone-1, BWCC.

MSME TECHNOLOGY CENTRE
Ministry of MSME, Government of India
Ministry of Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises, Govt. of NGA
600030 Industrial Estate, Chennai, Singapore

2 DAYS GOVERNMENT CERTIFICATE PROGRAM ON INCOME TAX PRACTITIONER

Course Duration 2 Days (ONLINE) Date: 21 & 22 March 2026
2 Days Time : 5:00 PM to 8:30 PM

Course Content: INCOME TAX RETURN FILING PROCESS, Slab Rates of Income Tax, Heads of Income, Income from Salary, Deductions from Salary, Clubbing of Income, Income from House Property, Home Loan Interest Deduction, Income from Business / Profession, Concept of Depreciation, Income from Capital Gains, Income from Other Sources Set off / Carry forward of losses, Deductions from Income (80C, 80D etc.), Forms for ITR, TDS RETURN FILING & TCS provisions More Topics

Fees : Rs.3,000/- (Study material in soft copy shall be provided)
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CINEMA ARTS EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Sri Rama Bhaktha Jana Samaj,
KK Nagar - 96770 63372 / 94441 88277

In Association with Avichi College of Arts Science, 42nd Sri Ramanavami Festival March 17th to 22nd Daily 6.30 pm Sri Rama Bhaktha Vijayam Discourse March 17th-18-20-21-22nd Sri Harji, and March 19th Harikatha by Smt. Vishaka Hari, March 22nd - 8 am: Lakshar-chanaai. Venue: Avichi College of Arts Science, Arcot Road, Virugambakkam. All are welcome.

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha (Regd.) Vanimahai.
Ph: 28152166

In association with Sri Kanchi Mahaswami Vidya Mandir Rajakilpakkam, Chennai, Integrated Enterprises (India) Ltd and City Union Bank celebrates 18th NAMASANKERTHANA VAIBHAVAM 2026 at Vani Mahal. Today 4.30 pm Tharangam by Mumbai Sri Sundaraman Bhagavathar and Party, 6.30 pm Nama Sankertthanam by Tiruvialur Sri Ramakrishnan Bhagavathar and Party. All are welcome.

MISCELLANEOUS

Narada Gana Sabha Trust
Ph: 24993201

Today Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall - 16th to 18th Daily at 6.30 pm - Sri R Krishnaswami Memorial Lecture - "Namasankeerthan Mummooorthigal - Sri Siddhara Ayyaval" - Satsang by H H Maharanayam Sri Sri Muralidhara Swamiji. All are welcome.

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PERSONAL	PERSONAL
CHANGE OF NAME	CHANGE OF NAME
I, SAHAYA Prakash Ratchakaraj, s/o: Ratsagaraj devasagayam, r/o: 1/204, Thiruvallur Street, Santhosapuram, Sembakkam, Tamil Nadu - 600072. Have changed my name as Sahaya Prakash Ratchagaraj.	I, NALINI daughter of S. Nagarajan resident of F-241 Dinesh Vihar, Sememcherry, Thazhambur, Chennai - 600130 have changed my Name from Nalini to Nalini Balakumar vide affidavit dated 11.03.2026 at Madras High Court, Chennai
I, RATCHAKARAJ / RATCHAGARAJ , s/o: Devasagayam, r/o: 1/204, Thiruvallur Street, Santhosapuram, Sembakkam, Tamil Nadu - 600072. Have changed my name as Ratsagaraj Devasagayam.	I, RAKUMAR Pillai Rajandran S/O K Rajandran, R/O Block 2 SE, Jain Alpine Meadows, Thirunermalai Road, Chromepet, Chennai-600044, declare that the names Rajakumar Pillai R. Rajakumar Pillai and Rajakumar Pillai (Rajendran) refer to one and the same person, myself. Henceforth I shall be known as Rajakumar Pillai Rajandran for all purposes.
I, RAMA LAKSHMI , w/o: K.N.Ganesan 793 years resident of New No.121, 86th Street, Ashok Nagar, Chennai 600083 shall henceforth be known and called as Ramalakshmi Ganesan vide affidavit dated 13.03.2026. RAMA LAKSHMI.	OLD AGE HOME
I, A Vanaja @ Venkataalakshmi, D/o N Alavanthar aged 41 years, Date of Birth 09/04/1985, residing at No 867, Siva Sakthi Nagar, Kollumedu, Vellur Post, Avadi, Thiruvallur Dist. 600092, Tamil Nadu, I have changed my name A Vanaja @ Venkataalakshmi to A Vanaja Venkataalakshmi.	PALLIATIVE CARE at your home Trained Nurses, 24/7, Dr., Physio visits, Lab tests 1800-513-1883 tikotra.com/seniors
I, N.KUMAR , S/o M.S.Nagarathnam aged 77yrs, residing at No.C2/19, Kendriya Vihar, Paruthipattu, Chennai-600071, have changed my Name from N.Kumar, to Kumar Nagarathnam vide affidavit dated 16-03-2026 High Court Chennai - N.Kumar	AUTOMOTIVE
I, A S VASAN , S/o Ananthachari, DOB: 01/07/1921 (Native District: Villupuram), Residing at No : 96 Bharathi Street, Pelakuppam road, Tindivanam, Villupuram 604001, Sathi henceforth be known as SEYON. (Father - K.Sukirtharaj)	FINANCIAL
I, B. Sai Azaad Reddy , S/o B. Satish Kumar Reddy, residing at 10/8 Golden Treasure Apartments Vanagaram Chennai 600095, have changed my name to Karthik Reddy B and shall hereafter be known as Karthik Reddy B for all purposes.	BANK DSA Organise MSME Fresh, Takeover Loans from Banks : 944481740
My Son SEYON SUKIRTHARAJ , Born on 29th July 2021 (Native District: Villupuram), Residing at No : 96 Bharathi Street, Pelakuppam road, Tindivanam, Villupuram 604001, Sathi henceforth be known as SEYON. (Father - K.Sukirtharaj)	HOME NEEDS
I, Manasi Manoj Jain D/O , Manoj Babulaji Jain R/o 1089 Ponmalallee High Road, B-1102 Vimalachal Apts. Chennai-600084 have changed my name to Manasi Jain.	Parryware always on fashion
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INBRIEF



Anna University signs MoU to establish advanced ERP lab

Anna University and Ramco Systems have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) for establishing an ERP laboratory at the university for its Industrial Engineering programme. Under the agreement, Ramco Systems will provide access to its cloud-based ERP platform to students through secured login credentials. It outlines a structured framework, including faculty enablement, industry-oriented training, skill development and provision for research and academic events. The MoU was signed by V. Kumaresan, Registrar-in-charge, Anna University, and Ravi Kula Chandran R., CFO, Ramco Systems.

Fire breaks out on Manali sub-station premises

A fire broke out on the Manali sub-station premises on Monday morning, triggering panic among motorists and passersby in the area. Police sources said that a spark from a high-power cable could have triggered the fire as it spilled onto furnace oil pools on the ground.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (March 17, Tuesday), the following articles are available:

- Why India must electrify its kitchens at scale newsth.live/electriccooking
 - India-made app turns impaired speech into clear speech in near-realtime newsth.live/speechapp
- You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Rain spell likely this week, to bring soaring temperatures down

RMC forecasts day temperatures may see a drop of one or two degrees Celsius; coastal districts to get light rainfall from March 20 to March 22

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Two minor weather systems are expected to influence wet weather conditions over different parts of the State this week and keep the soaring day temperature in check till March 22.

The Regional Meteorological Centre has forecast that day temperatures may begin to gradually fall by two degrees Celsius over Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, and Karaikal areas.

Some places may experience a drop in maximum temperature up to one or two degrees Celsius below normal from Wednesday onwards.

Officials of the RMC said an upper air cyclonic circulation persists over north coastal Tamil Nadu. Another trough from southwest Bay of Bengal off north Sri Lanka coast to Comorin area across Gulf of Mannar would trigger a spell of mild to moderate rainfall this week.

Moderate rainfall

While parts of Western ghats districts and south Tamil Nadu are likely to receive rainfall up to moderate intensity on Tuesday, thunderstorms may move to delta and adjoining districts on Wednesday and Thursday. Light rain may



Respite from heat: RMC officials said that an upper air cyclonic circulation persists over north coastal Tamil Nadu. Another trough from southwest Bay of Bengal would bring rain this week.

Western ghats districts and south Tamil Nadu likely to receive moderate rainfall on Tuesday

occur at one or two places in other districts too.

It may be the turn for coastal districts to receive light rainfall between March 20 and March 22.

V.R. Durai, Director, Area Cyclone Warning Centre, RMC, said this year, pre-monsoon rainfall activity was delayed over Kerala.

It is normal for the State to experience thunderstorm activity during March, and weather systems over Kerala may also influence wet spell in parts

of the State. This week's rain spell is likely to help soaring heat under control in many places, he said. On Monday, Karur Paramathi recorded hottest maximum temperature of 38.2 degrees Celsius in Tamil Nadu. Chennai Nungambakkam and Meenambakkam registered slightly below normal temperatures of 32.4 degrees Celsius and 33.9 degrees Celsius respectively.

Citing the seasonal outlook, Mr. Durai said the mean maximum temperature in most parts of the State in March is expected to be close to normal or below normal. Tamil Nadu may come under the grip of searing heat during April and May.

AAI makes a slew of changes in traffic flow at city airport

PORT CALL

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

At a time when air passengers find it challenging to navigate and reach the parking lot for boarding cabs, the Airports Authority of India (AAI) has introduced a new set of changes to vehicular movement at Chennai airport on Monday. This is being carried out to facilitate the ongoing construction of a part of the integrated international terminal (T3 terminal).

Most importantly, Chennai airport, which had two entry/exit points for vehicles, will have only one functional entry – the main gate on GST Road opposite Tirusulam station – temporarily, for the next 40 days.

Vehicles coming from Tambaram will not be able to enter through the second gate (located opposite PVR Galada Grand) and will have to enter only through the main gate on GST Road opposite to the station. AAI said traffic marshals will be deployed to prevent congestion and manage vehicle movement.

Vehicles which are heading to the departure level of the T4 Domestic Terminal will enter via the main GST Road gate, head straight, take the last right, climb over the bridge (left arm) and drop off passengers.

The vehicles that drop off passengers and return will take a u-turn (right in front of the T4 terminal)



Limited access: The airport will have only one entry on GST Road opposite Tirusulam station for the next 40 days. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

and will return through the same arm of this bridge through which they entered.

This could potentially cause congestion unless traffic is regulated well. Also, it is rather a bumpy ride for vehicles to climb this arm of the bridge as a small section of this arm is in poor shape.

If someone is coming to send off a passenger in T4 terminal, they can no longer just head to the parking lot. Instead, they have to exit the airport, enter the airport again via GST Road, park the vehicle at the multi-level car parking facility and walk down to the T4 terminal.

The connecting tube linking the T4 terminal with the west wing of the parking lot will also be closed for 40 days due to this ongoing construction work.

AAI has said access to T1 domestic terminal and T2 international terminal will continue as usual and these vehicle diversions

will not affect the passengers.

Transit passengers who have to shuttle between T1 domestic terminal and T2 international terminal can take the buggy vehicle as usual.

But, those transit passengers who have to travel between T1 domestic terminal and T4 domestic terminal will have to use a walkalator. The buggy vehicles will not shuttle between these two departure levels for this temporary period. Otherwise, these transit passengers will have to take a buggy vehicle at the arrival level, get dropped in front of the arrival hall at the T4 domestic terminal, and take a lift to the departure level.

One of the walkways has been closed and an alternative walkway has been provided.

AAI said these diversions and changes will be in effect only till structural steel erection work for the upcoming terminal is completed.

Man attacks estranged wife with iron rod, arrested

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police have arrested a 27-year-old man for allegedly attacking his estranged wife with an iron rod in Tiruvottiyur. On Saturday evening, when the victim went to a tailor shop, the accused, Harikaran, waylaid and abused her. He attacked her with an iron rod and threatened to kill her. He then fled the spot, the police said. The injured woman is being treated at a government hospital.

☀️🌧️ Timings CHENNAI			
TUESDAY, MAR. 17			
☀️ RISE	06:15	🌅 SET	18:20
🌧️ RISE	04:53	🌅 SET	16:54
WEDNESDAY, MAR. 18			
☀️ RISE	06:15	🌅 SET	18:20
🌧️ RISE	05:33	🌅 SET	17:47
THURSDAY, MAR. 19			
☀️ RISE	06:14	🌅 SET	18:20
🌧️ RISE	06:13	🌅 SET	18:40

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	34	21
Chennai Airport	34	24
Chennai City	32	24

Chennai Airport Today
34°C Morning will be pleasant. Day will be warm. Night also will be pleasant. Dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C The weather will be dry. Day will be warm. Night will be pleasant.

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THE HINDU
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Stranded in Doha, Chennai resident reaches Riyadh by road to fly back home

Shikha Kumari A.
CHENNAI

For more than a decade, international travel had been a routine part of Varun Krishnan's professional life. Each year, he would fly out to attend one of the world's largest technology conferences, moving through airports and transit hubs with the quiet predictability that frequent flyers come to expect.

This year's journey began in much the same way. He left Chennai for Barcelona on February 28 with a scheduled transit stop in Doha. But somewhere over West Asia, the routine began to change. "As we were approaching Iraqi airspace, I noticed on the flight map that we were slowing down and circling," Mr. Krishnan recalled. "Soon after, the captain announced that because of security concerns the flight would be returning to Doha."

By the time the aircraft landed, the regional security situation had worsened. Military escalation in parts of West Asia had triggered airspace restrictions, forcing airlines to cancel or re-route flights. One of the world's busiest transit hubs was suddenly dealing with uncertainty on a massive scale. Mr. Krishnan found himself among thousands of stranded passengers trying to understand what would happen next. "Emergency alerts started going off on our phones even before we landed," he said. "That was the first moment I realised how serious the situation was."

For several days, he remained in Doha waiting for



Varun Krishnan

clarity on flight schedules. The hotel accommodation arranged by the airline initially provided relief, but as cancellations continued, the experience became emotionally taxing.

Back in Chennai, his family followed every development with growing anxiety. Live television coverage of missile interceptions and escalating tensions made the distance feel smaller and the risks more immediate. His wife said maintaining calm at home became her biggest challenge. "He called us from the flight, and at first, I thought it was just a normal update," she said. "Then he explained that he was stranded. For the next few days, I hardly slept."

Another way out

The uncertainty took on a sharper edge one night when loud explosions were heard near the area where Mr. Krishnan was staying. "We woke up to the sound of blasts," he said. "From the upper floors of the hotel, we could see something burning in the distance. That was when I began to seriously think about finding another way out."

With flight options limited and no clear timeline

for normal operations to resume, he eventually decided to take an unconventional route. A group of travellers was planning a road journey across the desert to Saudi Arabia, hoping to secure onward flights from Riyadh. "A friend told me there was one seat available in their car," Mr. Krishnan recounted. "It felt like a risk, but at that point waiting also felt uncertain. So, I decided to go."

The journey involved hours of driving through remote stretches, multiple security checks, and tense moments at the border crossing. "Even while we were waiting at immigration, alerts about possible attacks were coming through," he said. "We were just hoping to cross safely."

After reaching Riyadh, he managed to eventually boarded a flight and reached India on March 7. "I have travelled abroad many times, but I have never felt more relieved to return home," he said. For his family, the relief was quieter but equally profound. "We are just grateful that he is back home safely," his wife said.

Mr. Krishnan's experience reflects the wider impact of geopolitical tensions on global mobility. Gulf transit hubs play a crucial role in connecting Asia, Europe, and North America.

Now back in Chennai, he says the episode has changed the way he views travel. What once seemed like a predictable system of schedules and connections now appears far more uncertain and fragile, Mr. Krishnan adds.

WANTED

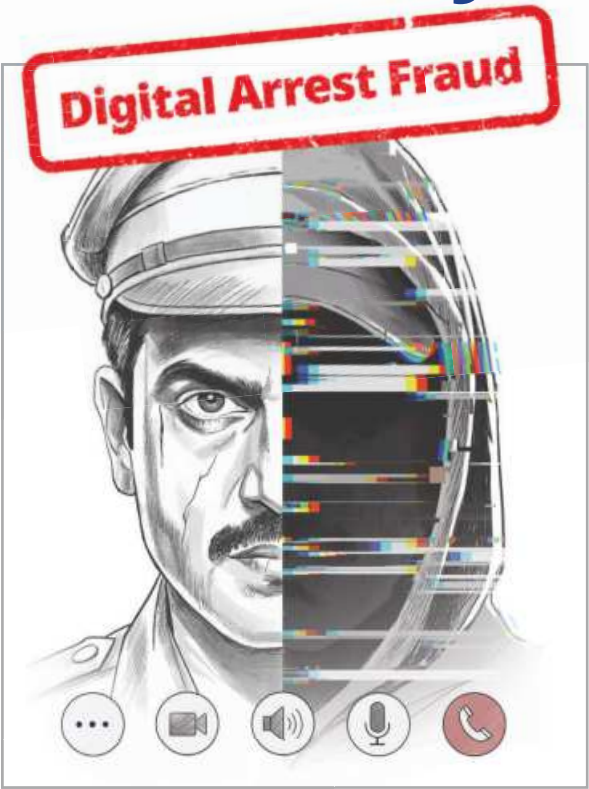
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ISSN 0971 - 751X

‘Need humane approach in Munambam land dispute’

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The plight of residents of Munambam, who purchased their holdings from Farook College, Kozhikode, needs to be approached from “a humanitarian” perspective and their interests need to be protected, according to Kerala Waqf Board chairperson K.S. Hamsa.

Speaking to mediapersons after assuming the charge of the chairperson on Monday, Mr. Hamsa, who stuck to the board’s earlier position that the controversial holding at Munambam was indeed a Waqf property, blamed Farook College, the Mutawalli (the manager of the Waqf), for the land dispute.

“It was the college authorities who committed the illegal acts, and the residents who purchased the holdings from them cannot be blamed for it... The residents shall not be burdened for the injustice committed by the college,” he said.

He further added: “At the same time, the Waqf property shall not be alienated and interests of the residents need to be protected. As the issue is pending before the Waqf Tribunal, the board will wait for the outcome to decide on the matter.”

Incidentally, the residents of Munambam had challenged the decision of the board notifying the holding as a Waqf property and including it in the board’s register.

Karnataka Speaker adjourns House as govt. delays replies

U.T. Khader halts proceedings over failure of govt. in responding to members’ queries; only 30% of unstarred questions receive replies, he notes; House resumes after talks with CM Siddaramaiah

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

In a rare development in the Karnataka Legislative Assembly, Speaker U.T. Khader on Monday abruptly adjourned the House, expressing disappointment with the Congress government for failing to provide answers to questions raised by members despite repeated directions.

The Speaker’s action – significant given that Mr. Khader himself is a Congress MLA from Mangaluru – came after Ministers and departments failed to submit written replies to a number of unstarred questions submitted by mem-



U.T. Khader

bers. Opposition members had been repeatedly complaining about this.

When the Speaker asked the government to table answers, Home Minister G. Parameshwara placed 84 replies against the 230 sought. Expressing strong displeasure, Mr. Khader said he had issued

clear directions from the Chair four times.

“This session is not meant for Ministers. It is meant for legislators who meet once in three months to raise issues concerning their constituencies. Only 15 starred questions are taken up during Question Hour. If a majority of unstarred questions go unanswered, why should members come to the House?” he asked.

Stating that there had been no improvement despite repeated warnings, he said, “Until the Ministers and the secretaries concerned explain this lapse, I will not run this House.” He went on to adjourn the proceedings.

Before adjournment, Leader of the Opposition R. Ashok said it was the fifth time the Speaker had warned the government over the issue. Last week, Mr. Khader had cautioned Ministers saying: “Just because I speak softly, do not mistake it for my weakness.” He had pointed out that only around 30% of unstarred questions had received replies.

After adjourning the House, the Speaker held a meeting with Chief Minister Siddaramaiah. Following the talks, he resumed the proceedings. Mr. Parameshwara assured members strict measures would be taken to prevent recurrence of such incidents.

Chinnaswamy Stadium to host IPL 2026 matches

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

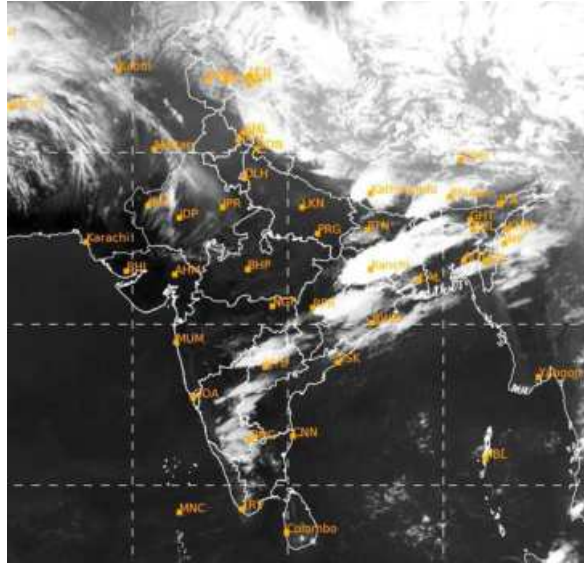
The Karnataka government on Monday officially cleared the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium for hosting IPL 2026 matches. The iconic venue was barred from hosting matches after the victory celebrations by Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) on June 4, 2025, resulted in a stampede that killed 11 people.

The government’s go-ahead comes after an expert committee submitted its assessment report.

The home team RCB will start their title-defending campaign against Sunrisers Hyderabad in the inaugural match on March 28. The Karnataka State Cricket Association will conduct two mock drills ahead of the match.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



Forecast for Tuesday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Assam and Meghalaya. Thunderstorm with lightning/gusty winds likely at isolated places over Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Karaikal and Kerala

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	
Agartala		32.8	23.0	Kozhikode		35.6	27.0	
Ahmedabad		37.7	22.6	Kurnool		37.4	24.7	
Aizawl		18.8	30.4	13.6	Lucknow		33.1	19.6
Allahabad		36.0	18.4	Madurai		37.0	24.4	
Bengaluru		32.8	22.0	Mangaluru		33.7	23.9	
Bhopal		35.2	20.0	Mumbai		31.7	23.0	
Bhubaneswar		32.2	22.6	Mysuru		34.6	19.8	
Chandigarh		16.6	26.4	12.3	New Delhi		0.4	32.2
Chennai		33.9	24.3	Patna		35.2	22.8	
Coimbatore		35.6	22.6	Port Blair		31.5	26.8	
Dehradun		25.5	28.5	11.4	Puducherry		32.2	24.0
Gangtok		19.7	10.5	Pune		37.1	20.4	
Goa		33.0	23.5	Raipur		37.7	25.0	
Guwahati		34.2	28.2	16.8	Ranchi		33.4	18.0
Hubballi		36.0	18.0	Shillong		20.0	13.0	
Hyderabad		36.0	23.5	Shimla		12.5	5.4	
Imphal		25.5	14.0	Srinagar		16.4	5.3	
Jaipur		33.9	18.6	Thiruvananthapuram		34.7	25.0	
Kochi		18.8	32.2	25.2	Tiruchi		35.7	24.4
Kohima		20.0	11.0	Vijayawada		33.9	22.6	
Kolkata		34.4	22.8	Visakhapatnam		31.5	24.7	

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE
Ahmedabad		82	94	60	105	174
Bengaluru		4	16	38	164	142
Chennai		6	13	51	17	40
Delhi		14	120	40	161	158
Hyderabad		2	9	47	74	100
Kolkata		11	96	21	40	58
Lucknow		13	41	26	58	103
Mumbai		14	70	16	33	88
Pune		32	16	90	105	96
Visakhapatnam		31	45	14	37	96

Yesterdays

In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Bynrihat, Assam recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 212 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Kohima, Nagaland recorded a healthy AQI score of 15

Air Quality Code: ● Poor ● Moderate ● Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose, throat, coughing, asthma, allergies and shortness of breath. Long-term lung irritation, heart disease, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

Crabs found with mixed-sex traits in Kerala

Aathira Haridas
KOCHI

A tiny crab displaying both male and female biological traits on the same body has been discovered in the Western Ghats.

Discovered from the forests of the Silent Valley National Park, this freshwater crab belongs to the species *Vela carli* and is both male and female at the same time.

The dual-sex condition

was observed in three crabs found in tree holes in Silent Valley.

Vela carli is an endemic freshwater crab found only in the forests and streams of the Central Western Ghats.

First such case

The study documents the first instance of gynandromorphy (a rare condition in which individuals exhibit both male and female characteristics) in *Vela car-*



This trait has never been reported in the *Gecarcinucidae* family. REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

li. This phenomenon is rare in *crustaceans* and has

never before been reported in the freshwater crab family *Gecarcinucidae*, according to the researchers.

The study was carried out by K.S. Anoop Das and K.T. Fahis from the Centre for Conservation Ecology, MES Mampad College, in collaboration with scientist and crab specialist Sameer K. Pati and Purnima Kumari from the Zoological Survey of India.

Their findings were recently published in the in-

ternational journal *Crustaceana*. Mr. Das, Head and Assistant Professor at the Centre, said that while gynandromorphy has been documented in several marine and freshwater crab families, it has not been reported in the family *Gecarcinucidae*.

“The bodies of the crabs displayed male reproductive structures, while other parts showcased female features, including gonopores,” said Mr. Das.

Pro-Kannada group warns of disrupting Railway exams today

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Opposing railway exams being conducted only in

Hindi and English, the Karnataka Rakshana Vedike has announced it would disrupt the exams scheduled to be held in Benga-

luru and Hubballi on Tuesday. South Western Railway is holding its promotion exams for 295 posts in Hubballi Division.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

It is with heavy hearts that we announce the passing of Mrs. Elizabeth Kurian (Jolla)- 82 yrs who left us on March 11th 2026 in Kottayam. She was the beloved wife of the late Mr. K. Kurian. A devoted educator, Elizabeth found great joy in teaching Physics and Mathematics while she lived in Chennai. She touched countless lives with her wisdom. Her legacy of knowledge and love remains a guiding light for us all. Funeral services to be held in Kottayam on 17/03/2026. Condolences can be sent to Sunil Kurian (Son) smkurian@hotmail.com.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

11TH YEAR ANNIVERSARY

01.10.1946

17.03.2015

G.S.RAMANIAH

A Man of Perfection! A Man of Humor! A Man of Simplicity!

It's been 11 years since you passed away, but you are in our thoughts every moment... We Miss You!!!

In remembrance of Wife: Shyamala, Son: Prasanna, Daughters: Chitra & Deepa, S-in-law: Anil Kumar, D-in-law: Suchitra Grandchildren: Kiran, Rahul & Janani

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

FIRST ANNIVERSARY

08.01.1927 - 17.03.2025

Shri. K. SUBBIAH B.E. IBS

Retired Director (All India Radio & Doordarshan)

Fondly Remembered by Wife, Son, Daughter-in-law, Grandchildren

IN MEMORIAM

DOB: 17.08.1960

17.03.2024

HEMALATHA ARULNAMI

We will Cherish you for ever

Fondly remembered by Arulnambi C K Priya/Srinivas, Ananth/Pavethra, Avira/Nilan/Agan. M: 98404-83998

BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE

113th BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE

17.03.1913

AMARAR THIRU M.A. KRISHNASWAMY

FOUNDER

KRISHNASWAMY EDUCATIONAL TRUST

Nungambakkam, Ch-34.

IN FOND MEMORY

M.A.K. Family Members, Staff & Students of

SHRI KRISHNASWAMY GROUP OF SCHOOLS

&

SHRI KRISHNASWAMY College for Women, Chennai.

BIRTH CENTENARY

Remembering the Master Craftsman on his Centenary Year - 2026

K.SHANKAR

— (1926 - 2006) —

Director · Editor · Writer · Producer

100+ Films in 6 Languages

a Lasting Legacy in Indian Cinema.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

IN LOVING MEMORY OF MAN WHO WELL LIVED AND LIVING IN OUR HEARTS FOREVER

14-04-1934

17-01-2023

KL. RAMANATHAN

GENERAL MANAGER RETIRED INDIAN BANK

Remembered On The 3rd Anniversary By Wife: Mrs. Vasantha Ramanathan

Son: Dr. Kulandayan Ramanathan & Mrs. Lakshmi Aronon Adalukommar & Aksharprey Vasantha

Daughters: Dr. Meenakshi Vairavan & Dr. Vairavan Dr. Kirrime Solai & Brinidhi Vasantha

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES

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SCIENCE EXPO ON ECO INNOVATION



Apex Pon Vidyashram, Velachery hosted a Science Expo titled “Eco Tech Extravaganza”, showcasing the creativity and innovation of their students. Students presented eco-friendly and technology-based projects focusing on renewable energy, waste management, water conservation, and sustainable living. The exhibits reflected strong scientific understanding, originality, and environmental awareness. The event highlighted the dedicated efforts of students, teachers, and supportive parents who contributed to its success. The expo inspired young minds to think innovatively and encouraged greater awareness about sustainable practices for a greener and better future.

KG ANNUAL SPORTS MEET

Dayasadan Agarwal Vidyalaya (DSAV) conducted their 6th KG Annual Sports Meet with enthusiastic participation from students of Pre-KG to UKG. The event was attended by Chief Guest Dr. P. S. Aravind Raj, Centre Director, Euro Kids, Koyambedu, and members of the management. The programme began with a prayer and lighting of the lamp, followed by the flag hoisting, pledge, and a march past by the students. Mass drill, aerobics, 50-metre races, and group games added excitement. A parent event and prize distribution ceremony marked the celebrations, highlighting teamwork and sportsmanship.



MINI CARROM CARNIVAL



Madras Christian College Matriculation Higher Secondary School, Chennai hosted a Mini Carrom Carnival in collaboration with the Tamil Nadu Carrom Association. Principal and Correspondent Mrs. Grace Sheela welcomed the dignitaries and highlighted the importance of sports in students’ lives. Chief Guest Mr. S. John Sundar, Additional Superintendent of Police, Chennai, inaugurated the event and addressed the gathering. Mr. R. Arokiajar, World No.2 Carrom Player and SAARC & Asian Champion, interacted with students. Mr. S. Antony Joel Prabu and Mr. Rajesh Moorthy R also encouraged students. The school thanked Mr. Praveen Kumar and Mr. Thirumal Vasan for their support.

For Subscription related queries, please contact Subramaniam P: Handphone: +91 98408 98088 | Email: subramaniam.p@thehindu.co.in



Poll bugles

Questions on the SIR apart, the ECI does well to limit the election cycle in April

The people of at least one State will heave a sigh of relief now that the schedule for five Assembly elections – all in April – has been announced. The elections in West Bengal will be held in two phases, unlike the eight in 2021. Spread across so many phases for security reasons, the extended campaigns only turned ugly and vituperative, with the parties stoking passions through personal attacks and communal rhetoric. It is to the credit of the Election Commission of India (ECI) that it has decided to limit the Bengal election to just two phases, which should hopefully focus the contestation and discourse on more pertinent issues. That said, these elections are the second set of polls being held in States/Union Territories (UT) where the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process has been completed. The ECI has yet to provide satisfactory explanations for the anomalies that arose during the SIR. These include a lowered gender ratio in most States except Tamil Nadu and an abnormally high number of deletions compared to the estimated adult population. The deletions are expected to affect short-term migrants and married women. Unlike Bihar, where the electoral variables were decisively in favour of the ruling National Democratic Alliance making the SIR a relative non-factor, it could affect West Bengal, where the sword of Damocles still hangs over 60 lakh people regarding their voting eligibility due to ‘logical discrepancies’ in their applications, which are still under review by judicial officers.

The other States and UT, barring Assam, that go to the polls also bring in a distinct element to them unlike most other Indian provinces. Here, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is less of a force and the elections will be decided based on the performance of State governments and local/regional variables. The entry of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, led by actor Vijay, and the staying power of the small but steady Naam Tamizhar Katchi party will complicate the battle in Tamil Nadu, even if it is being primarily fought between the two alliances led by the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam and the opposition All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam. In Kerala, the Left Democratic Front faces an uphill battle to counter anti-incumbency, with a resurgent Congress-led United Democratic Front challenging it, alongside a BJP seeking to expand its limited footprint. In Assam, the contest is between the two fronts led by the national parties, the ruling BJP and the Congress. The Congress’s inability to rope in the Rajior Dal led by Akhil Gogoi into its front is a failing that could hurt it in a contest that BJP Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma seeks to frame less as a referendum on governance and more around crass identity politics. This kind of a largely bipolar contest is also expected in Puducherry, where the ruling regional party, the All India NR Congress, in alliance with the BJP, will take on the Congress-DMK-Left-VCK coalition.

Beginning and end

The state must allow its citizens the right to die with dignity

The incontrovertible nature of both life and death makes them fendishly difficult to legislate or adjudicate. Interfering with the very elemental beginning and end points of life must seem daunting. Nothing else can explain the long dalliance that laws have had with euthanasia to facilitate the intentional ending of a life, globally. In India, last week, the Supreme Court, in a landmark decision, approved the withdrawal of life support, including artificial nutrition and hydration, for Harish Rana, who went into a persistent vegetative state (PVS) following a head injury over 12 years ago. Invoking the constitutional idea of dignity, the Court observed that it would not be compatible with temporarily keeping alive a terminally ill patient who is brain dead or in a PVS, only because it is possible to leverage technological advancements to do so. This forces a life of indignity: patients endure a slow, agonising death. As the end of life approaches, a loss of control over human faculties denudes life of its meaning, it added. The Court went on to expand the right to live with dignity under Article 21 to encompass the right to die with dignity. In India, in the absence of legislation on the subject, the courts have consistently had to engage with the euthanasia question over the years. The Smt. Gian Kaur vs The State Of Punjab (1996) case might have set off the trend, but the debate entered the public realm with the Aruna Shanbaug petition in 2011. The Court, in this instance, did not allow for euthanasia as the nurses caring for her demurred, but went on to lay down guidelines for withdrawing or the withholding of medical treatment or medical support to allow for natural death. In 2018, a Supreme Court Constitution Bench held that the right to die with dignity is a fundamental right.

Besides benefitting Harish Rana in the instant case, the judgment will undoubtedly make it easy for terminally ill patients and their families ‘to let go’. As technology advances in leaps and bounds, more life-preserving hacks will become available to all who are able to pay for them but could erode the patient’s dignity. The judgment is intended to introduce compassion into end-of-life care for patients with unalterable medical conditions. The concept of a living will, a legal document empowering individuals to state their preferences for medical treatment in situations where they become incapacitated, vegetative or are unable to communicate, again endorsed by the Court, must also be popularised. In the grey zones, it is the law that can give people the courage to take the right call.

With the sinking of the Iranian warship, *IRIS Dena*, in the Indian Ocean, by the United States on March 4, the war in West Asia came home to South Asia. With each passing day, the war that began on February 28 has reached South Asian homes in a number of ways – disrupting the availability of daily necessities, travel, trade, food and fuel for cooking and transport, fertilizers, and the safety of citizens in the West Asia region.

Approximately 25 million South Asians live and work in West Asia, including 10 million Indians, five million Pakistanis, between five to six million Bangladeshis, two million Nepalis, and significant numbers from Sri Lanka, Bhutan, and the Maldives. Afghans – between five to eight million – are refugees in Iran. In addition, Indians make up about 15% of the population of seafarers, or crew aboard merchant ships worldwide, along with other South Asians, all of whom are at risk of harm, particularly those positioned around the Strait of Hormuz, where Iran has weaponised access. As New Delhi formulates its next steps in the war, it is necessary to consider not only what it will mean for the whole region but also its own ties with each neighbour.

India’s stance could raise eyebrows

It is important to recognise that New Delhi’s posture at the start of the war – when U.S.-Israel strikes killed Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and much of his immediate family – has been out of step with most of the region. Bangladesh and Pakistan issued statements condoling Khamenei’s death almost immediately, the Maldives condemned the U.S.-Israel attacks on Iran and Iran’s counter-attacks equally, and the Sri Lankan Foreign Minister offered his condolences. In contrast, it took South Block five days to send Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri to the Iranian Embassy.

It took another week for the Ministry of External Affairs to express “grief” over the killing of more than 150 students and teachers at a school for girls abutting a naval base in Minab. Even in the wider region, a statement by Foreign Ministers of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) criticised U.S. and Israel for “initiating” attacks, and subsequent attacks by Iran.

This is less about optics and more about India’s – and South Asia’s – cultural values: the killing of Khamenei, an 86-year-old religious leader of a state, violated international norms, regardless of how his policies were viewed. That India’s statements in the following days condemned Iran’s retaliatory strikes without ever criticising U.S. or Israeli actions against Iran and Lebanon is an anomaly.

It is possible to explain the initial reactions in light of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s visit to



Suhasini Haidar

The conflict will test India’s regional influence and strategic balance

Israel two days before the strikes, and his statement in the Knesset that India would stand with Israel “in the moment and beyond”. But as the horror of the escalating war mounts and the Iranian regime demonstrates its resilience, there is a need to calibrate a more balanced response. India’s traditional position, of building strong bilateral ties with every country in West Asia, without taking sides in regional fault lines has always kept it in a position of trust and goodwill; this was proven during Mr. Modi’s outreach to Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian for the passage of Indian ships in the Strait of Hormuz.

In addition, the U.S.’s unabashed pride in bombing *IRIS Dena* near Sri Lanka without even attempting to help the surviving sailors has come as a shock to many in the region. It is admirable that the Indian Navy immediately assisted the Sri Lankan Navy in the rescue operations, and that both Delhi and Colombo offered safe harbour to other Iranian military ships in the area. Yet, the Indian Navy’s failure to express its condolences for the deaths of the sailors who had recently been its guests at India’s multinational naval exercise MILAN 2026 and the International Fleet Review in Visakhapatnam in February, is difficult to understand.

Economic, regional and maritime security

Going forward, India must reassure its neighbours – other than Pakistan, which it has no relationship with at present – that it remains cognisant of their concerns. As energy shortages deepened, New Delhi received requests for petrol and diesel from Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives; landlocked Nepal and Bhutan may follow suit if the situation worsens. India must plan ahead to avoid a repeat of 2021, when it had to halt vaccine supplies to its neighbourhood for several critical weeks to deal with the crisis caused by the spread of the delta variant of SARS-CoV-2. Subsequently, India’s “Vaccine Maitri” programme did much to ease those memories, and enforced the need for an “all of region” approach to such situations.

Since 2020, South Asia has been buffeted by several crises: COVID-19, supply chain blockages from India-China tensions along the Line of Actual Control, sanctions affecting grain, oil, and urea amid the Russia-Ukraine conflict, fluctuations in remittances due to constant flare-ups in West Asia, the impact of the Trump administration’s tariff policy on the region’s labour-intensive apparel and fashion industry, and seafood exports, and the growing shadow of Artificial Intelligence on jobs in a region with a restless young population.

It is not a coincidence that many of India’s neighbours have seen youth protests erupt, and new governments installed as a result – an example is Nepal’s election on March 5 which brought its first Gen-Z-led government to power.

Belém as a test of a new model of forest finance

The climate summit that was held in Belém, Brazil in November 2025, refocused renewed global attention to a difficult but unavoidable truth: protecting tropical forests requires more than ambitious pledges – it requires a fundamental shift in who holds power over those forests. As world leaders gathered in the Amazon city, the signature initiative was Brazil’s Tropical Forest Forever Facility (TFFF), or a finance mechanism presented as a paradigm shift in global conservation. Yet, amid the flurry of announcements and diplomacy, persistent tensions revealed that major challenges remain around participation, equity and accountability.

The difference

The TFFF proposes to compensate countries for maintaining standing forests, not just for avoiding deforestation. As reported, the Fund has already secured more than \$5.5 billion in initial commitments, including a \$3 billion pledge from Norway. Unlike many past funds, it is not structured purely as a donation vehicle. Rather, it is set up to generate returns and reward long-term forest conservation. Critically, at least 20% of its performance-based payments are reserved for indigenous peoples and local communities, whose daily stewardship plays an outside role in keeping forests intact.

This allocation is not symbolic. According to the Rainforest Foundation US, indigenous and local communities were deeply involved in co-designing the facility. Across months of global consultations, more than 400 community leaders shared their perspectives. The model offers something new: not only financial support but also formal decision-making power. Yet, important gaps remain. For instance, indigenous representatives do not have voting rights on the main governing bodies of the Fund, raising questions about how genuinely inclusive decision-making will be.

Even as the TFFF proposes this inclusive architecture, many civil society groups have



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The real test is whether it will protect the communities protecting the forest

voiced their strong criticism. The Global Forest Coalition (GFC) described the fund as “colonialistic”, arguing that it benefits intermediaries rather than forest peoples. Its worry was about a mechanism built around market logic and financial returns that may not address the root structural causes of deforestation, such as agribusiness expansion, oil and mining projects, and large infrastructure, all of which continue to drive forest loss. According to the GFC, rewarding standing forests without curbing exploitative activities risks creating a superficial conservation narrative.

Compounding this, some critics argue that the payment rate, around \$4 a hectare in earlier proposals, is inadequate given the manifold ecosystem services that forests provide. There is a risk that national governments could absorb most of the funds, while communities on the ground may see little benefit. The success of the TFFF, therefore, depends not just on its size but on strong delivery mechanisms and rigorous, locally accountable institutions.

Conservation overlooks power imbalances

Amid these debates, Brazil has taken steps to buttress access. On the sidelines of COP30, it announced a dedicated digital platform to help forest countries navigate TFFF eligibility. The platform, developed with partners such as the UNDP, FAO, WWF and the Global Alliance of Territorial Communities (GATC), promises technical assistance, capacity building and peer collaboration. It is stated that independence from the TFFF’s governing structures is meant to prevent conflict of interest while focusing on inclusion and knowledge sharing.

This structure matters because forest conservation has long overlooked deep power imbalances. For many indigenous groups, protecting the Amazon is not just an environmental fight but also a struggle for survival. This was clear at COP30, where indigenous protesters entered the venue

The Bharatiya Janata Party’s poll losses in the general election in 2024, which resulted in Mr. Modi’s first minority government within a coalition, are also attributed to the disaffection of unemployed and underemployed youth. The changes have impacted India’s diplomacy, as the Modi government has had to amend its more muscular neighbourhood policy to engage leaders elected on these mandates and who are less beholden to India.

India must also recognise that its position as “net security provider” in the region has been challenged by the U.S.’s sinking of the *IRIS Dena*, which cuts more deeply given their joint membership of the Quad (the strategic forum comprising the U.S., Japan, India, and Australia).

At their last meeting in July 2025, the Quad Foreign Ministers issued a statement reaffirming their commitment to “peace and stability” in the Indo-Pacific region and declaring that they “strongly oppose any unilateral actions that seek to change the status quo by force or coercion”, a reference to China. With the U.S. behaving unilaterally, India must move to strengthen its own coalitions in the maritime region, including the Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA), the Colombo Security Conclave, and the Information Fusion Centre - Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR) so that it is not caught unawares in the future. South Asia requires more regional trade, connectivity and energy sharing platforms, along with more conversations on regional security, as each country in the subcontinent is a stakeholder.

On the global stage, India’s position as Chair of the Quad requires it to host a summit this year – when U.S. President Donald Trump is to visit India. But India’s immediate priority should be to convene a Quad Foreign Ministers’ meeting to ensure better communication and chart a more stable course for the maritime region in view of the West Asia war.

New Delhi must restore the balance

On the other side of the global North-South divide, India is also due to convene the BRICS Summit in 2026 – while bringing current rivals and BRICS members Iran and the United Arab Emirates to the table may be difficult given current tensions, New Delhi’s diplomatic skills must be exerted in forging consensus for a BRICS statement that also highlights South Asia’s economic and security concerns. Having momentarily abandoned its balancing act between the U.S.-Israel and Iran, it is time for India to restore the balance in its West Asia policy. New Delhi’s traditional position on the tightrope may be tense, but it gives a more beneficial vantage point from which to steer the future of its people and those across the wider neighbourhood.

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Parliamentary proceedings

Reams have been written about the proceedings in Parliament. Yet, the ‘temple of democracy’ often resembles a marketplace. Questions are vital to governance as they expose flaws, but voices are frequently muted when they are raised. Listening appears to be on the wane,

while the ruling party and the Opposition behave like bitter adversaries. Disagreements need not be uncivil. By watching their representatives quarrel instead of seeking solutions, citizens can only reflect on the irony of such conduct in Parliament.

Balasubramaniam Pavani,
Secunderabad

Election conduct

It was ironic to hear the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) of India speak about democracy ahead of the Assembly elections. The CEC was right in saying that pure electoral rolls are the bedrock of any democracy (inside pages, March 16). But the conduct of elections

must also be free, fair, and impartial, with complete transparency at every stage. Democracy in elections will be meaningful only if the Election Commission of India recognises that it is an independent institution.

D. Sethuraman,
Chennai

India appears to have ensured that its own considerations take precedence over those of the electorate in the election dates it has announced. In Tamil Nadu, the polling date of April 23 falls in one of the hottest phases of the year. The day is also considered auspicious for weddings,

and several temple kumbabishekams are scheduled to take place. In 2023, poll dates in Rajasthan and Mizoram were revised due to local considerations.

A.V. Narayanan,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Importance of sex education in academia

Sexuality, intimacy, and mental health are closely linked yet heavily stigmatised, resulting in a culture of silence; shame and fear surrounding sex and intimacy can exacerbate mental health issues. The WHO has stated that “immense suffering can occur when people lack bodily autonomy, control over their fertility or the freedom to experience safe, consensual and satisfying sexual relationships”. In 2024, the Supreme Court emphasised the need for comprehensive sex education programmes in order to promote open discussions about intimacy and sexual health.

As German Academic Exchange Service (DAAD) fellows between Germany and India, the authors’ classroom experiences of teaching about the diversity of human sexualities, in both contexts, found that there is a need to resist and challenge the marginalisation, invalidation and disenfranchisement of lived intimacies in higher educational institutions. Deeply ingrained social stigmas, silence and taboos about intimate relationships are perpetuated in academia, evidenced by the miniscule number of courses and discussions on the topic. Academia often promotes a culture of resistance, fear and anxiety over informed exchange and empowering discourse, particularly in the light of increasing student suicides in India. By prioritising a biomedical approach as well as majoritarian norms, higher educational spaces disregard the dimension of pleasure and the impact of socio-cultural and oppressive factors on intimate experiences.

Lack of proper vocabulary
In India, the mental health curriculum is often found to be heteronormative and cisgendered without accounting for sexual marginalisation and human diversity. ‘Sexuality’ is limited to heterosexual dysfunctions, erasing



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By creating diversity-aware and compassionate learning environments, students can develop the tools to navigate contemporary challenges and create a more inclusive, equitable, and just world

topics such as consent and sexual politics, framing it as a medical issue alone. Complex lived realities and the structural violence faced by queer people are erased, inhibiting the development of cultural and structural competence required for effective clinical practice. As a consequence, sexual minorities often experience institutional discrimination and inadequacies in the provision of support when they access counselling services. With psychologists being increasingly appointed in universities to deal with suicide and mental health problems in India, such ethical and epistemic gaps fail to reckon with oppressive institutional contexts. It diminishes the capacity of mental health professionals to initiate transformative structural change oriented on sexuality, gender and relationship equality.

Exercises to open up
Addressing sensitive topics such as mental health, violence, and intimacy in higher educational settings comes with particular challenges. A workshop and film screening that took place at the University of Münster in Germany featuring a filmmaker who uses unconventional pornography as a form of sex education highlighted some of the difficulties. While appreciating the effort to tackle the issue, students found themselves uneasy during the discussion. Was it appropriate to open up about one’s own experiences, or was it safer to maintain a detached, impersonal, and abstract tone, as is often expected in academic settings? The authors’ interactions with students in India and Germany highlighted the importance of creating safer and accountable spaces when teaching sensitive topics. To achieve this, innovative approaches at the beginning of each class can help. Instead of diving straight into theory and methodology, icebreaker exercises and small-group discussions encourage students to share their

personal perspectives on topics. By answering questions like ‘What does intimacy mean to you?’, students can connect the course material to their own lives and experiences. Such an approach emphasises the need for instructors to foster a classroom environment that builds trust, rapport, and open communication among participants.

Inclusive classrooms
Education should harness the diversity within classrooms and transcend mere knowledge transfer and workforce training, aiming instead to cultivate critical thinking and awareness. This is particularly urgent in today’s context, where anti-democratic movements seek to erase and marginalise the experiences of LGBTQ+ individuals, promoting a narrow and exclusionary view of sexuality and intimacy. Furthermore, it is crucial to address the growing mental health concerns affecting young people, who face immense pressure from family expectations, societal demands, and the weight of multiple global crises. In 2025, the Supreme Court sought responses from the government on integrating transgender-inclusive comprehensive sexuality education into school curricula. In the same year, the Court issued pan-India guidelines to address suicide and mental health issues among students in which gender and sexual orientation figured as reasons for discrimination at higher educational institutions. By creating diversity-aware and compassionate learning environments, students can develop the tools to navigate contemporary challenges and create a more inclusive, equitable, and just world. Fostering allyship and care communities within educational institutions should take precedence over short-term fixes such as hiring more mental health professionals or facilitating isolated events or workshops, without creating a sustained conversation or support system.

Gaining inroads into each other’s bastions

Both the national parties, while tightening their hold, are keen to look beyond

STATE OF PLAY

Ashok Kumar
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The Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party’s (BJP) picks for the two seats to the Rajya Sabha that went to polls in Haryana on March 16 were predictable, as it was driven by caste calculations. The elections were necessitated due to BJP leaders – Kiran Choudhry, a Jat, and Ram Chander Jangra, belonging to the Backward Classes (BCs) – completing their respective terms in the Upper House. However, this time, the BJP chose to nominate Sanjay Bhatia, a Punjabi, in an effort to consolidate its non-Jat vote bank, and to tighten the grip over its regional bastion, the ‘GT Road belt’, a swath of constituencies along the National Highway (NH)-44. The Congress too stuck to its Jat-SC-Muslim formula, nominating Karamvir Boudh, who is from a Scheduled Caste (SC).

Even as the two national parties, which had finished neck-and-neck in the 2024 Assembly polls, vie to firmly hold on to their vote banks and regional strongholds in the State, they have also unleashed political battles to make inroads into each other’s traditional bastions.

Long-term game plan
After falling short of the majority mark in the previous Assembly election, the Congress undertook a major restructuring of its State unit last year. It appointed Rao Narendar Singh, a Backward Class leader, as its State party president – the first such appointment in over two decades, replacing a SC leader. In his appointment, the Grand Old Party is aiming to not just woo the



BCs, the core vote bank of the ruling BJP led by Chief Minister Nayab Saini, who also belongs to the BCs, but is also trying to breach the saffron party’s south Haryana fortress – the Ahirwal belt. The ‘Ahirs’ or the ‘Yadavs’, categorised as BCs in Haryana, and largely settled across the Gurugram-Rewari-Mahendragarh belt, have supported the BJP since 2014, playing a key role in the party’s record three consecutive wins in the State elections. With the appointment of Mr. Singh, an Ahir leader, the party hopes to cash in on the political rivalry between the BJP’s two Ahir stalwarts, Union Minister of State Rao Inderjit Singh and Haryana Environment Minister Rao Narbir Singh, to re-establish itself in the region. Of the 32 district presidents appointed by the Congress last year, 10 were from the Backward Classes, signalling the party’s shift away from its Jat-centric voter base towards a more inclusive caste coalition.

The BJP, for its part, thriving on a non-Jat and BC vote bank, has gradually increased its political outreach towards the Meo Muslims, who are the dominant group in at least five Assembly seats such as Nuh, Punhana, Ferozepur Jhirka, Hathin and Sohna. Over the past decade, Hindutva organisations have increased their activities in the Meo-Muslim dominated Nuh district. In December 2025, a 10-day ‘Vande

Bharat Ekta Yatra’ traversed through 200 villages in Nuh. Touted as an apolitical march to raise issues around poor infrastructure, it bore an unmistakable saffron stamp with several local BJP leaders taking part in it. The BJP has also been trying to lure prominent local political leaders from other parties as part of its long-term strategy to find a foothold in this region.

Regional players
Reduced from 31 MLAs in 2009 to just two in 2024, the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) has declared to take the fight to former Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda’s bastion Rohtak, the epicentre of Jat politics in Haryana. It held a rally in Rohtak last September to commemorate the 112th birth anniversary of late Deputy Prime Minister Chaudhary Devi Lal in order to reclaim its lost political ground in the Jat-dominated Sonapat-Rohtak-Jhajjar belt. The INLD, led by Abhay Chautala, hopes to turn around its political fortunes by winning back a portion of the Jat and Muslim vote bank, which has now shifted to the Congress. As part of its strategy, the party is set to hold a State-level youth conference in Jind’s Narwana on March 23 and organise several meetings in Nuh. Aiming to re-engage with its agrarian base, mostly the Jats, the Jannayak Janta Party too, led by Ajay Chautala, held a rally in the agricultural region of Hansi. Hansi is considered a bastion of the saffron party. Even as political parties in the State seek to chip away at each other’s vote banks, the BJP stands to benefit the most with the tug-of-war between the two Chautala-led factions and the Congress for the Jat vote bank, who form one-fifth of the total electorate.

Are 40 out of 100 children malnourished in Gujarat?

Data indicates that the statement is true and that there is a higher burden of malnutrition among the tribal communities of the State

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani

On March 12, child malnutrition in Gujarat became the subject of a debate in the Legislative Assembly. During a discussion on the budgetary demands of the Women and Child Development Department, Congress MLA Jignesh Mevani stated that, “despite..BJP government ...[having] more than 150 seats and 28 years of rule, only one figure comes on record, that 40 out of 100 children are malnourished. A very large section of them are tribals.”

Women and Child Development Minister Manisha Vakil responded that the Opposition was relying on figures from the National Family Health Survey (NFHS 2019-21) and asked members to “update your knowledge”. Ms. Vakil told the Assembly that, according to the Poshan Tracker system, “only 11.4% of children in Gujarat” were malnourished as of January 2026.

Different methods

The Poshan Tracker and the NFHS cannot be directly compared as they use different methods. The NFHS is a sample-based household survey conducted on a representative population, while the Poshan Tracker is a real-time monitoring system under Mission Poshan 2.0 that records growth data for children registered at *anganwadi* centres. “There are several issues in using Poshan Tracker data to counter NFHS figures. Poshan Tracker is supposed to be a complete census of children attending or at least enrolled at *anganwadis*, we do not know how complete the information is. NFHS data on the other hand is supposed to be representative of the entire population (including children who do not go to *anganwadis*),” said Economist Reetika Khera. The two datasets cover different populations and use different methods and

their figures are not strictly comparable.

“We do not know to what extent one can take Poshan Tracker data at face value. *Anganwadi* workers are under pressure to keep data entry on the Tracker updated and they experience all kinds of issues with the app and connectivity, so often they just enter some data, which may or may not reflect the child’s actual weight and height,” she added.

The latest publicly available Poshan Tracker data is for July 2025, and provides separate figures for stunting (low height for age), wasting (low weight for height) and underweight (low weight for age) rather than a single combined malnutrition percentage. It shows that about 32.7% of children were stunted, 7.2% were wasted and 18.4% were underweight in Gujarat (**Chart 1**). Among 36 States and Union Territories, the State ranks 21st in stunting and 31st in both wasting and underweight, placing it in the poorest performers bracket among States in key malnutrition indicators.

Poshan Tracker data for July 2025 shows that several States in central and eastern India rank near the bottom on these indicators. Bihar (9.3%), Chhattisgarh (7.7%) and Madhya Pradesh (8.1%) are among the worst performers in wasting, while Madhya Pradesh (24.8%) records the highest proportion of underweight children. In the case of stunting, Uttar Pradesh (48.8%) has the highest prevalence, followed by Jharkhand, Assam, Bihar and Madhya Pradesh, each with more than 42% of children found to be stunted. In contrast, States such as Goa, Sikkim, Manipur, Himachal Pradesh and Tamil Nadu rank among the better performers, reporting lower levels of stunting, wasting and underweight.

Verifying the claim
NFHS-5 (2019-21) is the latest round of the nationally representa-

tive survey on health and nutrition released so far, as the results for NFHS-6 (scheduled for 2023-24) are yet to be published.

In NFHS-5, 39% of children under the age of five in Gujarat were stunted, 25.1% were wasted, and 39.7% were underweight. NFHS does not report a single overall malnutrition percentage and these indicators are widely used to assess child malnutrition. The corresponding national averages were 36% for stunting, 19.3% for wasting and 32.1% for underweight (**Chart 2**). Stunting and underweight levels are both close to 40%, so the statement that around “40 out of 100 children” are malnourished is consistent with NFHS findings, depending on which indicator is used.

Mr. Mevani also said that “a large proportion of them belonged to tribal communities.” District level figures based on NFHS-5 show that several of the worst performing districts are among those identified as tribal districts by the Tribal Development Department of the Gujarat government (**Table 3**).

In the case of stunting, four of the five worst affected districts: Dahod (55.3% stunted), Chhota Udaipur (48.6%), Narmada (47.2%) and Panchmahal (47.1%) are tribal districts. Wasting shows a similar pattern, with The Dangs (40.9% wasted), Tapi (36.6%), Panchmahal (35.7%) and Sabarkantha (33.1%) also ranking among the highest, all of them tribal districts. In the case of underweight, all five of the worst affected districts are tribal districts: The Dangs (53.1% underweight), Dahod (53%), Narmada (52.8%), Panchmahal (51.9%) and Tapi (51.8%).

The claim that about 40% of children in Gujarat are malnourished is thus supported by NFHS-5 data, which shows that stunting and underweight levels are close to the claim. District level data also shows that several of the worst affected districts are tribal districts, pointing to a higher burden of malnutrition in tribal communities.

Scale of malnutrition

The data for the charts were sourced from the National Family Health Survey-5 (2019-21) and Rajya Sabha Question and Answers

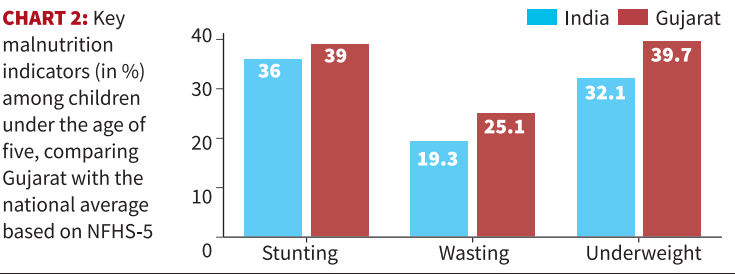
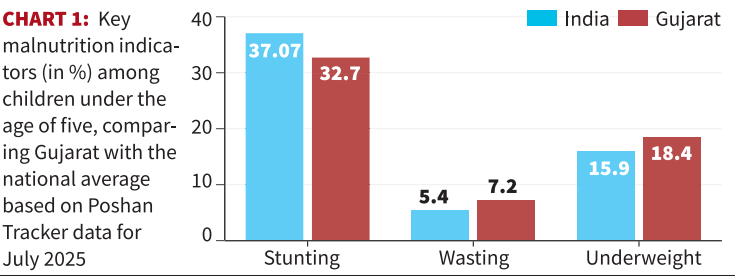


TABLE 3: Key malnutrition indicators (in %) among children under the age of five, across selected districts of Gujarat based on NFHS-5 with all the districts included identified as tribal districts

District	Stunted	Wasted	Underweight
Dahod	55.3	27.8	53
Chhota Udaipur	48.6	28.4	48.1
Narmada	47.2	23	52.8
Panchmahal	47.1	35.7	51.9
Aravali	47.1	29	47.2
Tapi	41.7	36.6	51.8
Bharuch	40.9	24.5	45.5
Banaskantha	39	25.5	44.1
Valsad	37.8	23.2	34.8
The Dangs	37.6	40.9	53.1
Sabarkantha	37	33.1	41
Navsari	36.8	29	43.6
Surat	36.1	26	32.5

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 17, 1976

A stamp not officially released

Mangalore, March 15: A stamp of Param Vir Chakra not officially issued by Postal Department, but stated to have leaked out prematurely, has become the star attraction in Mangalapex 76, the first ever district-level Philatelic Exhibition held here between March 12 and 14, sponsored by the P and T department.

The 25-paise denomination stamp was to have been officially released by the P and T Department on last Republic Day but was postponed, and the definite date of release is not fixed yet.

Meanwhile, the stamp has been issued from some post offices in the country and one stamp bearing a postmark of a post office in Tamil Nadu on Feb. 9 was on display from out of the collections of Dr. V.S. Prabhu of Mangalore and has been attracting attention of philatelists here. It was later found that Dr. K.S. Prabhakara Rao, founder President of the Philatelic Association of South Kanara, was also among those who has one such ‘Param Vir Chakra’ stamp having been defaced on March 12 from Belgaum.

Leading philatelists who are attending the Exhibition differ in their views regarding the philatelic value of such prematurely issued stamps.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 17, 1926

Broadcasting Parliament debates

London, March 15: In the Commons, replying to Mr. Campbell with regard to the broadcasting of proceedings of certain State legislatures of United States, Viscount Wolmer said he had seen reports that proceedings of Japanese Diet were broadcast last December and the proceedings of United States Senate were frequently broadcast. He had no information with regard to the results.

Mr. Applin asked for an assurance that the “mother of Parliaments” would be the father of broadcasting from Parliamentary viewpoint. (Cries of ‘No’)

Mr. Penny (Conservative) humorously declared that the medical profession had expressed opinion that there would be an outbreak of sleepy sickness if this was done. (Laughter)

From Page One

India to sign U.S. deal after clarity on tariffs

India and the U.S. announced a trade deal on February 2 and a joint statement on the finalisation of a framework for the deal was released on February 7. Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal had said that the deal would be signed in March.

The U.S. Supreme Court on February 20 ruled against the validity of U.S. President Donald Trump’s use of the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) to levy reciprocal tariffs on America’s trade partners. It is after this that the U.S. imposed the 10% tariffs on all its trade partners under Section 122 of the Trade Act, 1974. These tariffs are in force for a period of 150 days from February 24.

“The U.S. deal was to be signed in March. When we said this, at that time the Supreme Court judgement on IEEPA tariffs had not come,” the official explained. “Now with the Supreme Court judgement on IEEPA tariffs, the tariffs per se don’t exist.” Under the framework announced by the two countries, the U.S. was to impose an 18% tariff on India. Now, the new rate will depend on the rates the U.S. imposes on India’s competitors.

“Depending on how their tariff architecture settles, that will determine where India will land,” the official said. “In case all others are at 19% and above then India will remain at 18%. But if others come down, then India will also come down.”

On Russian oil

Mr. Agrawal also highlighted that the U.S.’ removal of tariffs on India is linked to its import of Russian oil. “On February 7, 2026, the 25% additional ad-valorem tariffs imposed by the U.S. on certain Indian exports citing India’s imports of Russian oil were removed,” Mr. Agrawal noted. “We can say that we are buying Russian oil and there has been an increased buying of Russian oil in the current month because of the challenges we are facing.”

10 dead as fire breaks out in Odisha hospital

The incident took place around 2.30 a.m. when relatives of patients observed smoke billowing out from the trauma care ICU where several accident victims were admitted in critical condition.

Though the fire service was immediately contacted, it took them about 30 minutes to reach the spot. By that time, hospital staff, security guards and relatives had already started efforts to extinguish the fire and shift the affected patients. However, patients were complaining about severe asphyxia in the smoke-filled hospital rooms.

“My father, Madhusudan Dalai, was grievously injured in an accident about 11 to 12 days ago. He was undergoing treatment in the ICU. His condition was fast improving. Doctors had told me that he might be released in a day or two. Around 3.30 a.m., I received a phone call that that fire had broken out in the ICU. When I reached the spot, my father had already lost his life,” said Amitabh Dalai, the patient’s son.

Patients were shifted to the New Medicine building and orthopaedic wards. As many as 11 hospital employees, including private security guards, sustained injuries. Their conditions were stated to be stable.

Terming the incident unfortunate and tragic, the Chief Minister announced *ex gratia* of ₹25 lakh each for the family members of the deceased.

President Droupadi Murmu condoled the loss of lives in the fire and wished for a speedy recovery of the injured. Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced that an *ex gratia* of ₹2 lakh from the Prime Minister’s National Relief Fund would be given to the next of kin of each deceased, and the injured would be given ₹50,000 each.

Mr. Majhi has constituted a high-level fact-finding team under the chairmanship of Development Commissioner Deoranjana Kumar Singh. He has also ordered a judicial probe to investigate the reasons behind the fire incident.

Protests held in Ladakh calling for Statehood

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Protest rallies were held in Ladakh on Monday, marking the first demonstration since violence erupted in September last year, on the call of the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) and the Leh Apex Body (LAB) to press for Statehood status and inclusion in the Sixth Schedule.

Hundreds of locals marched from Singay Namgyal Chowk up to Leh Polo Ground in Leh town. In Kargil, protesters held a rally. Protesters raised slogans that the current Union Territory status was unacceptable to the region.

“For the last six years, the people of Ladakh have been deprived of democratic representation and constitutional safeguards. The voices from the mountains are growing louder for justice. Although our activist Sonam Wangchuk has been released, our struggle for legitimate rights will continue. We also demand the release of Deldan Namgyal and Smanla Dorje,” a member of KDA, Sajjad Kargili, said.

NDA wins eight RS seats in Bihar, Odisha; Haryana results on hold

BJP national president Nitin Nabin and Bihar CM Nitish Kumar romp home as NDA secures all five Rajya Sabha seats in Bihar; the party also secures victory of three candidates in Odisha; BJP and the Congress file separate complaints in Haryana

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The National Democratic Alliance romped home with all five Rajya Sabha seats in Bihar and three in Odisha while the counting for the two seats in Haryana was delayed after the BJP and the Congress filed separate complaints.

A Congress delegation met the Election Commission (EC) in Delhi over the matter and submitted a memorandum, with Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge earlier writing to the EC alleging attempts to interfere with the integrity of the election.

Of the total 37 vacancies in Rajya Sabha, elections were held for only 11 seats in Bihar, Odisha and Haryana as the rest of the members were earlier elected unopposed.

In Odisha, the BJP secured the victory of three candidates, including Dilip Ray, a hotelier and Independent candidate it supported, while the Biju Jana-



(Left) Bihar Deputy CM Samrat Choudhary congratulates Nitin Nabin on his Rajya Sabha victory. Odisha CM Mohan Charan Majhi greets Manmohan Samal, Dilip Ray and Sujeet Kumar. ANI, BISWARANJAN ROUT



ta Dal (BJD) managed to win just one seat amid large scale cross-voting.

State BJP president Manmohan Samal, sitting BJP MP Sujeet Kumar and BJD candidate Sanrupta Mishra saw comfortable victories, with first preference votes from party MLAs. A fierce competition was expected between Mr. Ray and Dattaswar Ray, a “common” candidate announced by the BJD with support from the Congress

and Communist Party of India (Marxist). In the end, it turned out to be a one-sided fight with many Congress and BJD MLAs voting across party lines for Mr. Ray, one of founding members of the BJD. As many as 11 MLAs, including eight from BJD and three from Congress, had cross-voted.

In Haryana, where two Rajya Sabha seats were up for grabs, the process got stuck at the counting stage after the BJP and the Con-

gress filed separate complaints. The counting was to begin at 5 p.m., but had not begun at the time of filing of this report.

In Bihar, all five candidates of the NDA made it to the Rajya Sabha after four MLAs of the Opposition *Mahagatbandhan* did not turn up for the voting. All 202 MLAs of the NDA cast their votes, whereas only 37 MLAs from the *Mahagatbandhan* voted.

The five candidates who

secured victory included two from the BJP – national president Nitin Nabin and Shivesh Kumar and two from the Janata Dal (United) – Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and Ramnath Thakur. Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) president and former Union Minister Upendra Kushwaha also secured victory. Out of the six Congress MLAs, three skipped the voting process – Manohar Prasad Singh, Surendra Prasad and Manoj Bishwas. Rashtriya Janata Dal MLA Faisal Rahman also skipped voting.

There was a contest for the fifth seat between Mr. Shivesh Kumar and RJD candidate Amarendra Dhari Singh. As per the calculation, there was a requirement of 41 votes to win a seat from the NDA side and Mr. Shivesh Kumar got 38 votes whereas Mr. Singh got 37 votes. According to the Assembly Secretariat, Mr. Nitish Kumar and Mr. Nabin each secured 44 votes whereas Mr. Thakur and Mr. Kushwaha got 42 votes each.

Opposition notice seeking CEC’s removal cites his remarks against Rahul

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The notice seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar cites concerns ranging from the selection process for the post to his public confrontation with Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, and reports of widespread deletion of voters in Karnataka, an Opposition leader said on Monday.

The Opposition is yet to make the contents of the 10-page notice against Mr. Kumar public. The notice signed by 193 Opposition MPs – 130 in the Lok Sabha and 63 in the Rajya Sabha – has listed seven charges against Mr. Kumar including “partisan and discriminatory conduct”, “obstruction of inquiries into electoral fraud” and “mass disenfranchisement”.

The Opposition alleges that the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise was

The notice signed by 193 Opposition MPs has listed seven charges against Gyanesh Kumar

used to benefit the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party.

The notices, filed on Friday, follow months of Opposition protests over the SIR of electoral rolls. MPs have alleged “manipulation” of voter lists and accused the Election Commission (EC) of overlooking complaints of disenfranchisement.

According to an Opposition leader, the notices draw heavily from Mr. Gandhi’s February 2025 dissent note, submitted when Mr. Kumar was selected as CEC by the three-member committee comprising the Prime Minister, the Home Minister and the Leader of the Opposition. Mr. Gandhi had termed the government’s late-night decision to appoint the

CEC “disrespectful and discourteous”, pointing out that the committee’s composition and process were under challenge in the Supreme Court. The main point of contention has been the removal of Chief Justice of India from the selection committee, which now comprises the Prime Minister, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, and a Union Cabinet Minister, securing a majority for the government.

The notices also cite Mr. Kumar’s public ultimatum to Mr. Gandhi at an August 2025 press conference, where the CEC demanded that he either apologise or file a signed affidavit backing his allegations of “vote theft”. The Opposition parties said that such remarks were partisan and compromised the neutrality of the office.

They have also flagged alleged voter-roll manipulation in two Karnataka Assembly seats, Aland and Mahadevapura.

Centre responsible for the shortage of cooking gas: Kharge

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge on Monday held the Centre responsible for the ongoing LPG crisis, and accused it of failing to take pre-emptive measures despite knowing that the West Asia conflict could disrupt maritime routes and energy supplies.

Raising the issue during Zero Hour in the Upper House, Mr. Kharge said the government had not undertaken advance planning or arranged alternative import routes, even though India imports nearly 60% of its LPG needs, with 90% of these imports passing through the Strait of Hormuz.

The impact of the disruption was now visible across the country, from households to restaurants and MSMEs (micro, small and medium enterprises), of which many have scaled down or halted operations



Mallikarjun Kharge

due to non-availability of cylinders, Mr. Kharge said. Waiting time for refills had stretched to 25 days in urban centres, and up to 45 days in villages, triggering panic booking and fears of hoarding, he said.

Responding to Mr. Kharge, Union Health Minister and the Leader of the House J.P. Nadda accused the Congress of exploiting a national crisis for political gain instead of standing with the people. The LPG shortage, Mr. Nadda said, was an outcome of the West Asia conflict, in which India had “no contribution”.

Opposition targets Centre on LPG crisis, foreign policy

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Questioning the allocation of ₹57,381 crore for the Economic Stabilisation Fund, proposed by Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in the Appropriation Bill to address possible supply chain difficulties due to the conflict in West Asia, the Opposition said the crisis was “man-made”.

Participating in the discussion on the Bill, senior Congress MP Shaktisinh Gohil said that, since Independence, India had been committed to remaining non-aligned. The Strait of Hormuz is important to the interests of the country, Mr. Gohil said, adding that India’s relationship with Iran had been “very good” for many centuries. “There was no need to visit Israel,” Mr. Gohil said, criticising Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s recent visit to that country.

“Foreign policy should be in the interest of the country. Failure in maintaining good relations [with other countries] is the reason for such a huge demand [for an Economic Stabilisation Fund] now,” he said, adding that the Opposition was concerned with regard to the issue of cooking gas. “People are in long lines waiting for LPG,” Mr. Gohil said.

Deve Gowda writes to Sonia over ‘disruptions’ in Parliament

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Former Prime Minister and Janata Dal (Secular) leader H.D. Deve Gowda has written to Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi, expressing concern over “chaos” in and around Parliament, and raising questions on the conduct of the Leader of the Opposition in leading protests that have disrupted proceedings during the ongoing Budget Session.

In a letter dated March 16, Mr. Deve Gowda said he had been “greatly disturbed by a certain chaos that has been unthinkingly introduced inside the Parliament and in its larger premises, primarily by the Opposition parties.”



H.D. Deve Gowda

Mr. Deve Gowda said he had spent nearly 65 years as a legislator and parliamentarian, nearly 90% of which was on the Opposition benches. “You, yourself, have spent long years in the Opposition, and while there, you have conducted yourself with grace and maturity. Since this may well turn out to be the

last parliamentary session of my life, I feel compelled to say a few things with the hope that it will lead to the gradual restoration of parliamentary traditions and decorum,” he said.

“I strongly feel that Congress parliamentarians, led by the Leader of Opposition (LoP), have provoked far too many disruptions inside Parliament and in its premises,” he said. The veteran leader said such actions had created an “attitude of non-seriousness”.

Acknowledging that the role of the Opposition was to highlight the shortcomings of the government, Mr. Deve Gowda said this must be done through “well-established and time-tested methods”, urging Ms. Gandhi to intervene.

Govt., Opposition reach consensus to revoke suspension of eight MPs

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The suspension of eight Opposition MPs from the Lok Sabha is likely to be revoked on Tuesday, after the government and Opposition parties on Monday reached a consensus on the issue at a meeting of floor leaders convened by Speaker Om Birla.

Sources said that parties agreed that members would not cross over into the Well of the House to oppose those on the other side, throw papers at the Speaker’s podium or protest at the desk of the secretary general.

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju, senior Congress leader K. C. Venugopal, Congress chief



Suspended Congress MPs protest at the Parliament premises over the nationwide shortage of LPG gas cylinders on Monday. ANI

whip K. Suresh, Samajwadi Party leader Dharmendra Yadav, Trinamool Congress’ Satabdi Roy and Supriya Sule of the NCP were among those present at the meeting. Among NDA leaders, Union MinisterRajeev

Ranjan Singh and Shrikant Shinde of the Shiv Sena were present.

On February 3, seven Congress MPs and one CPI (M) MP were suspended for unruly behaviour following a resolution passed by

the Lok Sabha during the first part of the Budget session. The suspended members are Gurjeet Singh Aujla, Hibi Eden, C. Kiran Kumar Reddy, Amarinder Singh Raja Warring, Manickam Tagore, Prashant Padole and Dean Kuriakose (all Congress) and S Ventakesan of the CPI(M).

Issuing a bulletin, the Lok Sabha secretariat reminded members that Speaker Om Birla has barred placards, posters and banners from being brought into Parliament. “It has also come to light that AI-generated portraits, pictures and slogans of a derogatory nature are being displayed on several of these posters,” it said, urging members to comply with the directions.

BJP MP Arun Singh contested him and claimed that leaders of the Congress and Samajwadi Party (SP) were hoarding gas cylinders to create panic among the public. Iran had assured safe passage for Indian ships, and ships with petroleum products had started reaching the Indian coast, Mr. Singh said.

Communist Party of India-Marxist (CPI-M) MP John Brittas questioned the government’s silence on the war against Iran. It was impacting India’s economy, Mr. Brittas said.

“When over 60% of the strait comes under the control of Iran, what was the need to have an adverse relationship with Iran?”, Aam Aadmi Party’s (AAP) Sanjay Singh, said

Nearly 50% of voters in Assam are women

▼ Almost 50% of the 2.5 crore electorate in Assam are women, the State's Chief Electoral Officer, Anurag Goel, said on Monday.

Of the 2,50,21,413 voters registered so far, 1,25,04,501 are women, accounting for 49.97%. The list has 321 third gender voters. Mr. Goel said 1.64 lakh voters were added

to the 2.49 crore electors named in the final list of voters published on February 10.

“We will continue to update the list until the last day of filing of nomination papers,” he said. Filing of nominations for the election on April 9 began on Monday and will continue until March 23, Mr. Goel said. According to the Election Commission, 6,28,093 voters are first-timers in the 18-19 years age group, while 2,482 voters are aged over 100.



Women show their voter cards during the 2024 Lok Sabha election in Assam. FILE PHOTO

Rajior Dal not to contest against Gaurav Gogoi

▼ Activist-turned-MLA Akhil Gogoi's Rajior Dal has offered a strategic understanding with the Congress despite the two parties failing to ally.

Mr. Akhil Gogoi, president of the Rajior Dal, has asked his party not to field a candidate against his Congress counterpart, Gaurav Gogoi, in the Jorhat Assembly

seat. The constituency is part of the Jorhat Lok Sabha constituency, which the latter represents.

“As an experienced parliamentarian, Gaurav Gogoi knows the Constitution of India and can contribute to law-making, unlike most of our MLAs. This is why I want him to enter the Assam Assembly,” the Rajior Dal chief said.

The Congress and the Rajior Dal are rivals in three seats — Dhemaji, Goalpara East, and Margherita.



Trinamool has been in power for 15 years, and the promises they made have not been kept. BJP, too, makes big speeches but does not do anything

G.A. MIR
Congress leader

47% MLAs in Bengal face criminal cases

▼ Nearly half of West Bengal MLAs face criminal charges while over half are crorepatis, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms and West Bengal Election Watch. It found that 136 MLAs (47%) have declared criminal cases and that 152 out of the 291 MLAs analysed (52%) are crorepatis. PTI



In the next 23 days till the poll date, we will present issues that are affecting the people of the State. We are not interested in any controversy

RAJEEV CHANDRASEKHAR
BJP Kerala president



Star contestant: Leader of the Opposition Suwendu Adhikari has been fielded from two constituencies. ANI

BJP announces candidates for 144 Bengal seats

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday announced its first list of 144 candidates for the Assembly election in West Bengal.

Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Suwendu Adhikari will contest from two constituencies – Nandigram in Purba Medinipur district and Bhabanipur in Kolkata. Former State BJP president Dilip Ghosh has been nominated from Kharagpur Sadar, while former Rajya Sabha MP Swapan Dasgupta has been fielded from Kolkata's Rashbehari.

The saffron party has given ticket to 41 MLAs, three former MLAs, and two former MPs. The list has 11 women, but no Muslim candidates.

Among the sitting MLAs, the BJP has renominated Agnimitra Paul from Asansol Dakshin (Paschim Bardhaman district), Chandana Bauri from Saltora (Bankura), Shikha Chatterjee from Dabgram-Phulbari (Jalpaiguri), and Malati Rava Roy from Tufanganj (Cooch Behar).

Sitting MLA Shankar Ghosh is contesting again from Siliguri in Darjeeling district and actor-turned-politician Rudranil Ghosh is contesting from Shipbur in Howrah. Former Barrackpore MP Arjun Singh's son Pawan Singh, who is also the MLA of Bhatpara Assembly, is defending his seat.

However, the biggest highlight of the list has been the fielding of Mr. Adhikari from Bhabanipur, where Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee is the MLA. In the 2021 Assembly election, Mr. Adhikari had defeated Ms. Banerjee from Nandigram by a margin of 1,956 votes.

The Chief Minister had to return to Bhabanipur and get herself elected to the West Bengal Assembly in a byelection.

192 candidates in Left Front list

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

The CPI (Marxist)-led Left Front on Monday released its candidate for 192 of 294 Assembly constituencies for the coming West Bengal Assembly election. Party veterans along with emerging youth leaders have made the list, which also includes 27 women candidates.

The highlight of the list is Sabina Yasmin from Kaliganj Assembly seat. Ms. Yasmin is the mother of nine-year-old Tamanna Khatun, who was killed in political violence on June 23, 2025. Trinamool Congress workers hurled crude bombs on her residence after winning the Assembly byelections killing the child on the spot.

Some of the most important faces to emerge in the list are women youth leaders Minakshi Mukherjee, who will contest from Uttarpur, and Dipsita Dhar, from Dum Dum Uttar. Former Kolkata Mayor and Rajya Sabha member Bikash Ranjan Bhattacharya, from Jadavpur, and former MLA and senior minority leader Deblina Hembram, from Ranibandh, are among the other notable names in the first list.

The Congress and the Left Front fielding candidates separately marks the end of almost a decade of understanding between the two political forces. In the last Assembly election in 2021, the Left Front and the Congress drew a blank, while the Indian Secular Front (ISF) won one seat.

LDF seeks third term, UDF readies to end 10-year drought; BJP a bystander

A good outing in the 2025 local body polls has energised the UDF that seeks to deny the LDF a hat-trick in Kerala; amid welfare promises, the West Asia war may dominate political discourse; the BJP hopes to make a mark, having won a Lok Sabha seat and the Thiruvananthapuram corporation

IN FOCUS

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The battle lines in Kerala for the 2026 Assembly election have been drawn, and the impending poll campaign may have the makings of a close race.

The ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF), weighed down by 10 years of incumbency, is seeking to defy the odds and return to power for a third consecutive term. It is also battling dissidents.

Out of power for two consecutive terms, the polls pose an existential threat to the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF). However, a remarkable performance in the 2025 local body elections has put a spring in the UDF's step.

The BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) draws strength from its show in the 2024 Lok Sabha election and it helming the prestigious Thiruvananthapuram Municipal Corporation. The BJP seeks to end what it perceives as the “bane of LDF-UDF revolving door politics”.

Gulf conflict

The polls will be fought under the shadow of the West Asia war and the economic uncertainty caused by looming fuel shortages. The families of an estimated 3.5 million Keralites em-

Mapping Kerala's elections

Kerala's 2026 Assembly election is shaping into a three-front contest, with LDF seeking a third term as UDF resurgence and BJP's ambitions reshape the polls

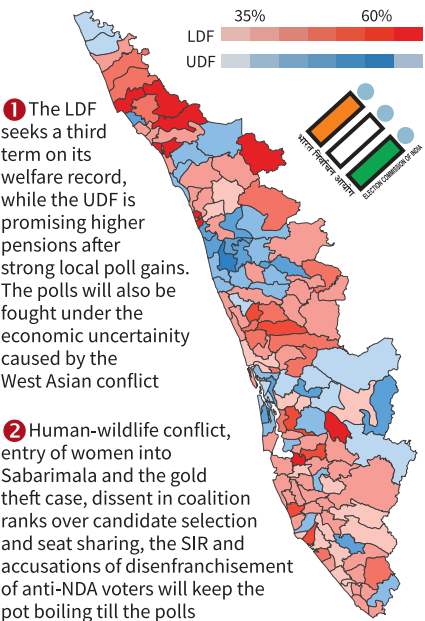


A worker arranging poll materials of different political parties at a store in Thiruvananthapuram. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

The map shows region-wise breakup of Kerala's electoral constituencies, according to CSDS classifications

- Malabar: 48 seats
- Cochin: 44 seats
- Travancore: 48 seats

The map shows alliance-wise results of Kerala's 2021 Assembly election results. The darker the shade, the higher the vote share (in %)



1 The LDF seeks a third term on its welfare record, while the UDF is promising higher pensions after strong local poll gains. The polls will also be fought under the economic uncertainty caused by the West Asian conflict

2 Human-wildlife conflict, entry of women into Sabarimala and the gold theft case, dissent in coalition ranks over candidate selection and seat sharing, the SIR and accusations of disenfranchisement of anti-NDA voters will keep the pot boiling till the polls

Party-wise results-2021

Party	Seats
CPI(M)	62
CPI	17
KC(M)	5
JD(S)	2
NCP	2
INL	1
LJD	1
NSC	1
KC(B)	1
C(S)	1
JKC	1
IND	5
INC	21
IUML	15
KEC	2
KC(J)	1
RMPI	1
IND	1
LDF	99
UDF	41

played in West Asian countries comprise a significant section of the electorate. The conflict, including the attacks on Gaza, may also influence, in some measure, the voting behaviour of the Muslim community in the State, who comprise an estimated 26.56% of the population as per the 2011 Census.

The LDF and UDF calculus seems centred on the conjecture that the BJP's strong showing in at least 30 Assembly seats in the 2024 Lok Sabha election and its performance in several State elections might push the Muslim community towards the traditional fronts.

The LDF will bank on its track record in social welfare and development. As many as 62 lakh voters, chiefly the elderly, widows, persons with disabilities, and agricultural labourers, draw a monthly pension of ₹2,000. The UDF has sought to outmatch the LDF by promising to hike the dole to ₹3,000 if voted to power.

The BJP believes that the LDF's social welfare pitch alone will not sway the middle-class voters. Both the BJP and the UDF will put to intense scrutiny the LDF's claims of large-scale investment, critical infrastructure development, job creation, limiting inflation,

improving public health-care and providing free housing.

Several undercurrents could influence the outcome of this election. The LDF and the Congress fear that the BJP's inroads into the influential Nair and Ezhava Hindu communities could dent their respective strongholds.

The BJP's overtures to Christians, particularly to Church-backed settler farmers in the hill districts, have influenced the LDF and the UDF's strategising.

Human-wildlife conflict, entry of women into Sabarimala and the gold theft case, dissent in coalition ranks over candidate selec-

tion and seat sharing, the SIR and accusations of disenfranchisement of anti-NDA voters will keep the pot boiling till the polls.

Key contests

The State is also bracing for high-profile contests. Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee president Sunny Joseph is likely to face former Health Minister K. K. Shailaja in Peravoor in Kannur. BJP State president Rajeev Chandrasekhar is contesting against CPI(M) State Committee member and Education Minister V. Sivankutty in Nemom, Thiruvananthapuram.

Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and Leader of the

Opposition V. D. Satheesan are contesting from Dharwadom (Kannur) and Paravur (Ernakulam), respectively.

Former Union Minister V. Muraliedharan will take on CPI(M) State committee member and former Devaswom Minister Kadakkampally Surendran in Kazhakkootam Assembly constituency in Thiruvananthapuram.

Former Minister G. Sudhakaran, who left the CPI(M) after being denied a seat citing age and term limit, is contesting against CPI(M) MLA H. Salam, in Ambalappuzha, with UDF support. Kerala Congress (M) chairperson Jose K. Mani is contesting from Pala in Kottayam, a seat long held by his father, the late K. M. Mani, but where Mr. Jose was defeated by the UDF's Mani K. Kappan in 2021.

CPI(M) Kannur district secretariat member T. K. Govindan is contesting as an Independent from Taliparamba constituency, accusing the CPI(M) State secretary M. V. Govindan of nepotism. Senior CPI(M) leader and Mr. M. V. Govindan's wife, P. K. Shyamala, is the LDF candidate in the Assembly segment. Former Kerala BJP president K. Surendran is contesting from Manjeswaram in Kasaragod, where he lost in 2016 and 2021.

The Assembly election for 140 seats in the State will be held on April 9, with counting on May 4.

Congress accuses EC of bias over poll schedule

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress general secretary (organisation) K. C. Venugopal on Monday accused the Election Commission of bias in announcing the poll schedule, claiming that the dates had been designed to restrict the party's campaign window.

He criticised the decision to hold the first phase of polling on April 9 in States where the Congress is a key contender. “There seems to be no urgency as the results will be announced only on May 4,” he said. Assam, Kerala, and Puducherry will vote in a single phase on April 9.

He said after the last date for withdrawal of nominations, candidates would get barely 10 days for campaigning as the period coincides with the Holy Week, referring to Good Friday and the Vishu festival. About Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, where polling is scheduled in later phases, he said the dates were intended to curtail campaigning by Congress candidates and leaders.

Poll body transfers top bureaucrats, senior police officers in West Bengal

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Hours after the announcement of Assembly election in West Bengal, the Election Commission late on Sunday transferred the Chief Secretary, Home Secretary, and the Director-General of Police, among others.

While there have been instances of transfer of key officials of West Bengal during previous elections, such sweeping transfers are unprecedented in the administrative history of the State.

The EC transferred Nandini Chakravorty and appointed Dushyant Nariala as the Chief Secretary. Mr. Nariala is an IAS officer of the 1993 batch and was serving as Additional Chief Secretary of North Bengal Development Department.

The poll panel appointed Sanghamitra Ghosh as the Home Secretary replacing Jagdish Prasad Meena. Ms. Ghosh is a 1997-batch IAS officer and was holding charge of Secretary of the Women and Child Development Department.



Leading lady: West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee at a protest rally against LPG price hike and supply crisis in Kolkata on Monday. PTI

Officers who have been transferred will not be part of active election duty, says Election Commission

The Commission also transferred the DGP, Peeyush Pandey, and Kolkata Police Commissioner Supratim Sarkar.

Siddh Nath Gupta, a 1992-batch IPS officer, has been appointed the DGP in-charge of the State. Ajay Kumar Nand, an IPS officer of 1996 batch, has been appointed the new Commissioner of Kolkata Police.

The Commission also replaced ADG (law and or-

der) West Bengal Police Vineet Goyal with Ajay Mukund Ranade, a 1995-batch IPS officer.

The EC said the officers who had been transferred would be kept away from active election duty. Most of the officers transferred had been in office for only a few months and were given key posts after a series of reshuffles by the State government.

Taking strong exception to the transfers put in effect by the EC, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee said, “It does not matter who you [EC] appoint as replacement officers. They will all work for us, they all will work for Bengal.”

“Change everything but you will not be able to change the government in the State,” the Trinamool Congress chairperson said during a public rally in Kolkata.

‘Anti-women, Bengal’

In the past, Ms. Banerjee had reinstated transferred officers to their position soon after elections. “They chose the hour of midnight to remove Nandini Chakravorty, the Chief Secretary and a Bengali woman, without consulting the State government. It goes to show how anti-women they are... Our Home Secretary is a non-Bengali person. His removal reflects the deep disdain they have for efficient officers of Bengal,” she said.

CPI(M) State Secretary Mohammad Salim said officials at the ground level who were engaging in electoral irregularities should be transferred. Mr. Salim said it was not about transfer of officials as “the people will transfer the entire government”. The Assembly polls in the State will be held in two phases on April 23 and 29.

Trinamool MPs boycott RS sitting in protest

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Protesting against the removal of top bureaucrats in West Bengal by the Election Commission ahead of the Assembly election in the State, Trinamool Congress members on Monday walked out of the Rajya Sabha, boycotting its sitting for the day.

Speaking in the House, the party's Rajya Sabha leader Derek O'Brien said, “In the dead of night, the Chief Secretary and Home Secretary have been removed by the Election Commission. They have all the power to do it.”

He said the Trinamool did not seek to disrupt the proceedings of the Upper House and would stay away.

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju condemned their action. “He is raising the matter about a constitutional authority, which this house or the government has nothing to do with. If every member wants to question a constitutional authority... it is not wise,” he said.

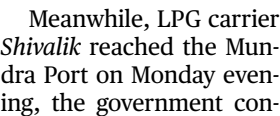
The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Bhopal Gas Peedith Sangharsh Sahyog Samiti to approach the Madhya Pradesh High Court with their concerns about the disposal of hazardous residual ash that remains after the incineration of toxic waste from the site of the infamous Bhopal gas tragedy at Union Carbide India Ltd (UCIL) in Bhopal. About 337 tonnes of hazardous waste from UCIL was incinerated, generating nearly 900 tonnes of toxic residual ash early last year. The hazardous waste was the fall-out of one of the biggest industrial disasters globally which took place in December 1984 when methyl isocyanate gas leaked out of the UCIL plant site and claimed over 5400 lives.

A court in Gujarat's Gir Somnath district on Monday convicted five persons and acquitted 35 others in connection with the 2016 Una Dalit flogging case in which four members of a Dalit family, who traditionally worked as leather tanners, were attacked by over 40 members of an upper caste community for alleged cow slaughter. The verdict regarding a juvenile accused in the case is still pending. Proceedings against one police constable ended after he died while the trial was under way. Punishment for the five convicts will be announced on Tuesday.

The Sahitya Akademi on Monday announced its awards for 2025 in the 24 languages recognised by it, nearly three months after the process was abruptly put on hold following directives from the Union Culture Ministry. Among the winners are former diplomat Navtej Sarna, awarded in the English language category for his novel *Crimson Spring*; Hindi writer Mamta Kalita for her memoir *Jeete Jee Allahabad*; and Tamil author Sa Tamilselvan for his work *Thamizh Sirukathaiyin Thadangal* in the literary criticism genre. The awardees will receive an engraved copper plaque, a shawl, and ₹1 lakh. The announcement was delayed after the Culture Ministry cited a need for “restructuring” of the awards.

The Supreme Court on Monday disposed of a petition filed by Ashoka University Associate Professor Ali Khan Mahmudabad to quash criminal proceedings instituted against him for his social media posts on Operation Sindoor after the Haryana government informed the court that it had refused sanction for his prosecution. In a previous hearing, a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant had asked the Haryana government to refuse sanction as a “one-time gesture of magnanimity”. The State, on Monday, appearing through Additional Solicitor-General S.V. Raju, said it had accepted the court’s suggestion.

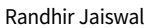
Sources said that naval ship escort to Indian merchant ships will continue to be provided. Some 22 Indian-flagged ships are still stranded west of the strait.



Nanda Devi, another LPG carrier, is expected to reach Kandla port on Tuesday. Individually, the vessels are holding 46,000 tonnes of cargo, cumulatively, 92,172 tonnes. "Seafarers on board are all safe and would be reaching tomorrow at Mundra port," Mr. Sinha said. *Jag Laadki* will

Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson at the External Affairs Ministry, said the issue had not been taken up in any bilateral setting.

The report further said that bilateral trade policies with India should be linked to “improvements in religious freedoms”.



"Instead of persisting with selective criticism of India, USCIRF would do well to reflect on the disturbing incidents of vandalism and attacks on Hindu temples in the United States," Mr. Jaiswal said.

‘Needs attention’

"Growing intolerance and intimidation of members of the Indian diaspora in the United States merit serious attention," Mr. Jaiswal added.

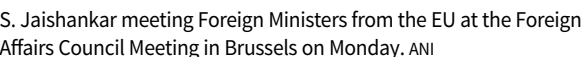
There have been several incidents of violence against individuals belonging to the Indian community in the U.S. as well as members of the Indian diaspora in the U.S. in recent years.

There have also been several incidents of vandalism at Hindu temples and properties that India has urged the U.S. to address.

Against this backdrop, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Monday met Ajay Malik, Assistant Commandant of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), who lost a leg in an improvised Explosive Device blast during an anti-Maoist operation in Jharkhand on March 1. Mr. Malik who was airlifted to the AIIMS, Delhi

Presently, 20% of posts in the rank of Deputy Inspector-General and 50% of posts in the rank of Inspector-General in the CAPFs are reserved for IPS officers through an executive order. The total strength of the CAPF is around 10 lakh, which includes 13,000 Group A cadre officers. The Home Ministry is the cadre controlling authority of both the CAPFs and IPS.

“We also discussed developments in the Middle East and in Ukraine. De-escalation, stability and energy security are our shared objectives,” Ms. Von der Leyen said in a post on X, about her meeting with Mr. Jaishankar. The EU and India were focused on implementing the trade deal signed in January in New



Thanking the EU's top diplomat Kaja Kallas for inviting him to the Foreign Affairs Council, Mr. Jaishankar said, "Our conversation today therefore covered trade, investment, technology, mobility and defence in particular."

“The stronger convergence between India and the EU in a multipolar world is also expressed in

closer consultations," he added, saying West Asia, Ukraine, and the Indo-Pacific were discussed at the meeting. On Sunday, Mr. Jaishankar publicly thanked Armenia for the safe evacuation of 550 Indian nationals from Iran.

Ahead of the meeting, Ms. Kallas had outlined various options the EU was considering to open the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial body of water through

which a quarter of the world's oil passes.

Mr. Jaishankar had said that India would be happy to share what New Delhi was doing with Tehran, with European countries, although he acknowledged that every country had a different relationship with Iran. He had also said there was no *quid pro quo* involved with Iran permitting the passage of two Indian-flagged tankers carrying LPG crossing the Strait on Saturday, saying this was based on a “history of dealing” with each other.

Calling the conflict “most unfortunate”, he called for other countries to engage with Tehran. The Minister had also emphasised that India did not have a “blanket arrangement” with Tehran for safe passage of ships, but it was being arranged on a case-by-case basis and discussions were ongoing.

Gudi Padwa is a special festival for Maharashtra and Goa. It is celebrated on the first day of the Chaitra month which synchronises with the first day of the new moon. This day signifies the beginning of the new year, the heralding of spring and the harvesting of rabi crops. This is also the day when it is believed that Brahma created the universe and the sense of time. Lord Rama returned to Ayodhya on this day. Some rural Marathi and Konkani Hindu communities bond with Lord Siva's cosmic dancing and congregate together at Siva temples. People in Maharashtra also celebrate the day by commemorating the famous ruler Shivaji's victory over the Mughals, said Prof. Kumool Abbi.

The festival is celebrated by cleaning and decorating homes with rangoli. The day starts by consuming the bitter neem and jaggery, which is believed to purify the body, which expresses the acceptance of both bitter and sweet experiences, characterising life. Preparation of sweets such as puran poli, basundi and kesari bath is also made in earnest. The day is considered auspicious to start new undertakings, business ventures, vastu puja and investing in gold and silver and buying new vehicles.

The word Gudi Padwa has a very interesting meaning and significance. Padwa refers to the first day of the lunar fortnight, while Gudi refers to a flag made of bamboo that is anointed with garlands of flowers, mango and neem leaves, sugar crystals and an overturned silver or copper vessel.

As the flag is hoisted, it brings good luck, eclipsing all negativity. Gudi is hoisted on the right side of the house. All the constituents of Gudi signify something.

INBRIEF



Gujarat's GMDC, NMDC ink pact on rare earth elements

A Government of Gujarat enterprise Gujarat Mineral Development Corporation (GMDC) has entered into an MoU with central public sector enterprise NMDC to explore opportunities for collaboration in the Rare Earth Elements (REE) sector. Both organisations, under the MoU, will work together to evaluate opportunities for technical collaboration, project development and potential business structures. The focus will be assessing the potential development of an integrated rare earth value chain in Gujarat, including exploration, mining, beneficiation, processing and downstream applications. The engagement will primarily explore opportunities associated with GMDC's Ambadungar Rare Earth deposit. The partnership is also expected to facilitate knowledge exchange, technical evaluation and coordinated efforts towards advancing rare earth resource development, GMDC said on Monday.

RIL, Samsung C&T ink \$3 bn green ammonia supply pact

Reliance Industries Ltd. (RIL), developing a fully integrated new energy platform spanning renewable energy, energy storage, green hydrogen, downstream green fuels and chemicals, said it has entered into a binding long-term supply and purchase agreement (SPA) with Samsung C&T Corporation, South Korea, for the supply of Green Ammonia over a 15-year period commencing in the second half of FY2029. The SPA, valued at more than \$3 billion, is one of the largest binding long-term Green Ammonia off-take agreements globally, the company said. "The SPA sets a new benchmark in the global energy landscape, with India emerging as an exporter of green fuels produced through an end-to-end value chain anchored in the country," it added.

PhonePe defers IPO, cites global pressures and volatile markets

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

PhonePe said it had 'temporarily deferred' its public market listing process due to the current geopolitical conflict and market volatility. The listing process will resume once there is some stability in global capital markets, the company said in a statement.

"We sincerely hope for a swift return to peace in all the affected regions. We remain committed to a public listing in India," said CEO Sameer Nigam.

Walmart will trim its stake in PhonePe by about 12% in the IPO, while Tiger



Sameer Nigam

Global and Microsoft plan to exit their stakes, according to the firm's IPO filing. The three firms will sell around 50.7 million shares in the offering, and PhonePe will not issue any new shares.

(With inputs from Reuters)

Goods export flat in Feb.; official sees dip in March on conflict

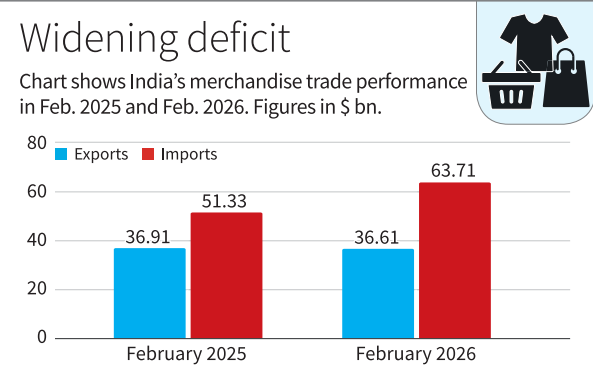
Commerce Secretary Agrawal noted March may be challenging on account of logistical issues on West Asia crisis, while releasing Feb. data

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India's trade balance stood at a deficit of about \$4 billion in February compared with a surplus of \$2.7 billion a year earlier due in large part to merchandise exports staying flat while imports of both merchandise and services grew significantly during the month. Releasing the data, Commerce Secretary Rakesh Agrawal said exports in March are likely to be impacted by the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

As per the Ministry of Commerce and Industry data, total exports, including merchandise and services, grew 11% to \$76.1 billion, while total imports rose 21.7% to \$80.1 billion.

Within this, merchandise imports widened gap over exports. Merchandise exports were largely flat at



\$36.6 billion in February compared with \$36.9 billion a year earlier. Merchandise imports, however, climbed 24.2% to \$63.7 billion over this period.

'Likely to worsen'

Mr. Agrawal said the situation may worsen in March on West Asia crisis.

"Despite all the challenges, our merchandise exports have been doing well," Mr. Agrawal told the press. "The month of

March will be a challenging one as well, because of too many logistics challenges, and when one part of the geography gets constrained, then too much of exports will not happen. Exports will likely see a downward trend this month because of the logistical challenges."

In February, services exports climbed almost 25% to \$39.5 billion while imports grew almost 13% to \$16.4 billion.

Gem and jewellery export rises 4% in Feb. amid tariffs

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The overall gross exports of gems and jewellery in February grew 3.86% (8.37% in rupee terms) year-on-year (YoY) to \$2.68

billion (₹24,340.05 crore), as per data from the Gem & Jewellery Export Promotion Council (GJEPIC).

For the period April 2025 to February 2026, the overall gross exports of gems and jewellery marginally

grew 0.07% (4.34% in rupee terms) YoY to \$25.93 billion (₹2,28,230.06 crore).

The data comes as a relief as the sector could do well despite the heavy tariff imposed by U.S. President

Sensex, Nifty50 surge 1.1% as concerns over energy supply ease

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

India's benchmark indices climbed 1.1% after concerns over energy supply eased with two Indian ships transporting LPG to India for the first time since the Iran war began.

Nifty50 and BSE Sensex30 opened at 23,116.10 and 74,415.79 respectively with a slight dip reaching the day's low after trading for more than an hour. The indices gradually gained and touched a high of 23,502 and 75,805.27 before closing at 23,408.80 and 75,502.85 respectively.

The optimism was not broad-based with about 2,212 stocks advancing and 1,074 stocks declining in over 3,371 stocks that traded on Monday on the NSE. Just six of the 21 NSE sectoral indices were positive.

The benchmarks had slid over 5% last week.

While the indices show signs of optimism, it has not reflected in oil prices and foreign exchange rates. Brent Crude Futures continued to trade at about



A man outside the BSE.

\$102 a barrel and rupee at over ₹92 a dollar. Besides, wholesale inflation came in at a 11-month high of 2.3% in February 2026.

"The sentiment was under pressure during the first half due to the global oil benchmark rising by about 1.7% to \$105/barrel. However, markets rebounded sharply on reports the U.S. was preparing to form a coalition to escort ships via Strait of Hormuz, easing concerns over disruptions to global energy supplies," said Siddhartha Khemka, head of research, wealth management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd.

MARKETS

MARKET WATCH

	MONDAY	% CHANGE
Sensex	75,503	1.26
US Dollar	92.28	----
Brent oil	101.85	----

NIFTY 50

	PRICE	CHANGE
Adani Enter.....	1978.00	16.90
Adani Ports.....	1373.90	10.70
Apollo Hosp.....	7490.00	-60.00
Asian Paints.....	2217.70	20.90
Axis Bank.....	1214.70	17.40
Bajaj Auto.....	9073.00	198.00
Bajaj Finserv.....	1773.90	35.90
Bajaj Finance.....	878.15	23.10
Bharat Elec.....	429.50	-9.90
Bharti Airtel.....	1788.80	-14.60
Cipla.....	1300.00	-14.70
Coal India.....	460.30	-6.70
Dr Reddys Lab.....	1276.90	-15.40
Eicher Motors.....	6827.50	86.50
Eternal Ltd.....	222.04	6.36
Grasim Ind.....	2654.40	85.80
HCL Tech.....	1328.60	3.20
HDFC Bank.....	840.60	23.60
HDFC Life.....	626.00	0.25
Hindalco.....	921.15	11.10
Hind Unilever.....	2175.70	15.70
ICI Bank.....	1272.90	18.10
Int'lGlobeAvl.....	4222.10	63.90
Infosys.....	1249.80	1.50
ITC.....	308.25	6.80
Jio Financial Service.....	234.35	-0.90
JSW Steel.....	1145.60	26.30
Kotak Bank.....	369.85	3.00
L&T.....	3469.40	30.40
M&M.....	3036.10	105.00
Maruti Suzuki.....	12757.00	166.00
Max Healthcare.....	970.60	-19.40
NestleIndia.....	1213.40	11.20
NTPC.....	382.40	-2.05
ONGC.....	260.45	-3.65
PowerGrid Corp.....	297.75	-3.20
Reliance Ind.....	1395.10	14.40
SBI Life.....	1909.20	4.80
State Bank.....	1066.70	19.70
Shriram Finance.....	992.00	-11.60
Sun Pharma.....	1783.20	-18.40
TataConsumerProduct.....	1092.70	9.10
Tata Steel.....	186.94	3.43
TCS.....	2409.20	-3.30
Tech Mahindra.....	1339.50	-6.70
Titan.....	4090.80	17.60
Tata Motors PV.....	314.40	0.30
Trent Ltd.....	3596.10	108.30
UltraTech Cement.....	11099.00	483.00
Wipro.....	195.11	-2.47

Feb. WPI at 11-month high

Wholesale price index (WPI)-based inflation rose to a 11-month high of 2.13% in February on an uptick in prices of food and non-food articles, even though vegetable prices eased. PTI

Travelstack, Learnfluence, Tea Post get nod for IPO

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Three companies – travel technology firm Travelstack Tech, Learnfluence Education, which operates the 'Lakshya' coaching centres, and tea cafe chain Tea Post – have received approval from SEBI to raise funds through initial public offerings (IPOs), according to an update from the market regulator on Monday.

The development comes at a time when Indian equity markets are under pressure due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

So far this year, 12 companies have tapped the IPO market to raise funds.

Banks report highest contraction in MFI portfolios in Q3 FY26

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Banks' microfinance portfolio outstanding contracted by 40% year-on-year to ₹65,687 crore in third quarter of FY26, according to a report released on Monday.

The fall is the sharpest among all categories of lenders, which also includes dedicated non-bank finance companies – MFIs (microfinance institutions) and small finance banks, according to the report by a credit information company.

Persistent stress in asset quality led to tightening of underwriting standards

like adoption of guardrails to restrict number of loans and leverage at a borrower level, as per the report by Equifax and SIDBI.

Liquidity constraints

Liquidity constraints particularly in smaller lenders also led to lower disbursements, the report stated.

The overall industry portfolio outstanding was down 22% year-on-year and 7% sequentially in December, 2025.

The largest contraction has been seen by banks, followed by 25% for small finance banks, 22% by not-for-profit MFIs and others, 14% and 4% by NBFC-MFIs and NBFCs, respectively.

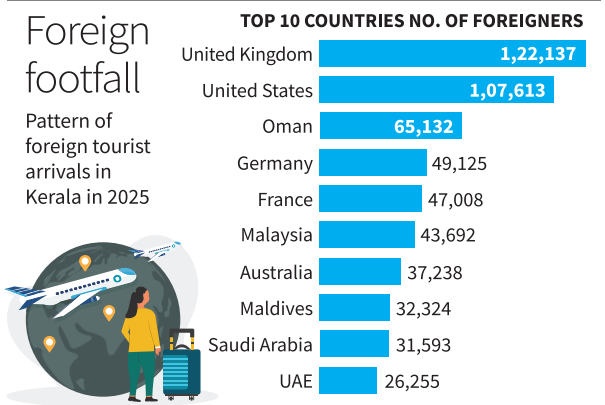
West Asia crisis ails Kerala's wellness sector

Dhinesh Kallungal
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

As neighbouring Colombo has introduced fuel rationing amid a drop in tourist arrivals following the escalating war between Iran and the combined forces of the U.S. and Israel, the hospitality sector in Kerala, which contributes around 10% of the State's Gross Domestic Product, is staring at a bleak future with a large number of cancellations, including in the medical tourism segment.

Kerala is considered the cradle of wellness tourism in the country, and nearly 70% of the foreign tourists visiting the State belong to this category.

About 85% of the foreigners visiting the State use either Doha or Dubai as transit points to reach Kerala, in the absence of



direct flights connecting the State with Europe.

This movement has come to a halt following the outbreak of the war, leading to cancellations and postponements.

According to Sajeev Kurup, general secretary of the Confederation of Kerala Tourism Industries (CKTI) and chairman of the Ayurveda Task Force of

FICCI's National Tourism Committee, the sector is facing an unprecedented crisis with travel restrictions coupled with an energy crisis.

"Despite the foreign tourist season nearing its fag end in Kerala, which usually begins in October-November and ends by March, the sector has already lost 20-25% of its business. There have also been no bookings for the next season since the war began.

The hospitality sector is also unable to operate smoothly due to shortages of commercial LPG, and the issue is likely to snowball into a major crisis if the war continues, especially once the Assembly elections in the country are over," said Mr. Kurup.

The crisis is likely to lead to lay-offs and cost-cutting measures once the upcoming domestic tourist season in April and May is over. According to James Kodianthara, former chairperson of the Kerala chapter of the Indian Association of Tour Operators (IATO), the domestic tourism sector will also be impacted by the disruption of global energy supply chains with the closure of

restaurants.

The next financial year will be a difficult period for the sector unless the Centre introduces support measures such as the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS), which was rolled out during the COVID-19 pandemic, he said.

A foreign tourist visiting Kerala for medical tourism, particularly Ayurveda, typically spends two to three weeks in the State, significantly contributing to the local economy.

In 2025, about 8.21 lakh foreign tourists visited various destinations in Kerala, according to statistics from the State Tourism Department, compared with 7.38 lakh in 2023.

The United Kingdom and the United States together accounted for about 2.23 lakh visitors last year.

TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS, TIRUPATI
BIRRD (T) HOSPITAL, TTD, TIRUPATI

NOTIFICATION
RECRUITMENT OF DOCTORS ON CONTRACT BASIS AT BIRRD (T) HOSPITAL, TTD, Tirupati
Reg.No.TTD-104021(31)/122/2021-BIRRD **Dated: 16.03.2026**

The notification issued for recruitment of Doctors (i.e. Professor, Associate Professor, Asst. Professor, Med. Officer, Residents) on Contract for 2 years at BIRRD Trust Hospital, Tirupati is extended upto 31.03.2026 due to administrative reasons. Eligible doctors from across the country shall apply and may submit their applications **on or before 31.03.2026** and candidates who already applied need not apply once again. For further details log in www.tirumala.org.

TTD-40021/10/2025-PRO SEC(Adv.No.436),Date: 16.03.2026 **EXECUTIVE OFFICER**

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विक्रम साराभाई अंतरिक्ष केंद्र / VIKRAM SARABHAI SPACE CENTRE
निर्माण एवं अन्वेषण ग्रुप / CONSTRUCTION AND MAINTENANCE GROUP
तिरुवनन्तपुरम / THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - 22 / (फोन नं. / Ph. No. 0471 - 2564568 / 4545)

ई-निविदा आमंत्रित करते हुए संक्षिप्त सूचना / BRIEF NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER **दिनांक/Dated : 16-03-2026**

भारत के राष्ट्रपति की ओर से निम्नलिखित कार्यों के लिए ई-टेंडरिंग द्वारा ऑनलाइन मद-दर निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। On behalf of the President of India, online item-rate tenders are invited through E-tendering for the following works.

1. दर्या, वीएएसएससी में जल दमन परीक्षण सुविधा के लिए विद्युत कार्य / Electrical works for High Pressure Test Facility at TERLS, VSSC / **NIT No. VSSC/CMG/E01/35/2025-2026 Dated 16.03.2026** (पी.ए.सी./P.A.C.: ₹65.43 लाख/Lakhs)
खजनालोक करने की अवधि / Period for downloading: दिनांक: 17.03.2026, 11.00 बजे/hrs. से/ to दिनांक 29.03.2026, 23.00 बजे/ hrs.
ई-निविदा की अवधि बढ़ाना / EXTENSION OF E-TENDER

1. वीआरसी मुख्य भवन फेज-II, वीएएसएससी के संवर्धन हेतु वातावरण नियंत्रण कार्य / Airconditioning works for augmentation of VRC Main Building Phase-II, VSSC. **NIT No. VSSC/CMG/A01/07/2025-2026 Dated 19.02.2026**
खजनालोक करने की अवधि / Period for downloading: दिनांक: 22.03.2026, 23.00 बजे तक ब्यापार/ Extended upto 23:00 hrs. on 22.03.2026
इच्छुक निविदाकार यहाँ से के लिए www.tenderwizards.in/isro या www.isro.gov.in देखें। Interested tenderers may visit www.tenderwizards.in/isro or www.isro.gov.in for details.

Sd/- प्रधान, सीएएमजी, वीएएसएससी / Head, CMG, VSSC

BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED
Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, 1st Floor,
BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru – 560 052

No:DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/30/2025-26 **Date:16.03.2026**

SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through GOK KPP Portal Only) Call-02

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the works. The details of the tender is as below.

Pkg. No.	Name of the works	Approx. Amount put to tender (Rs. in lakhs) Excluding GST	EMD (Amount in Rs.)	Time of Completion
P1	Social Media Activities under SBM 2.0 With the following activities-Call-02. a) Dissemination through Reputed Radio during the large events and Swachh Survekshan under Social Media Activities of SBMU 2.0 b) Social Media Campaign for activities under Mid Media Component under Social Media Activities of SBMU 2.0 c) Digital Awareness Drive under Social Media Activities of SBMU 2.0	408.26	Rs.1,00,000/- through e-payment under of the following i.e., online / RTGS / NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.5,13,000/- by Bank Guarantee / FDR issued by Nationalized/ Scheduled Bank	3 Years
P2	Mid Media Activities under SBM 2.0 With the following activities-Call-02. a) Large Scale Events including clubbed with workshops, marathon, plogging, signature campaigns-Large scale events including clubbed with workshops, marathon, plogging, signature campaigns under Mid Media Activities SBMU 2.0 b) Ministry based programmes under SBM 2.0 - Programmes and events created by MoHUA which includes – world toilet day, swachhta pakhwa, Indian swachhta league, 3R Promotion, swachh Diwali, swachhta hi seva et., under Mid Media Activities SBMU 2.0	588.47	Rs.1,00,000/- through e-payment under of the following i.e., online / RTGS / NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.7,83,000/- by Bank Guarantee / FDR issued by Nationalized/ Scheduled Bank	2 Years

Calendar of Events: 1) Last Date for Uploading Pre bid Queries: 19.03.2026 at 17:30 hrs. 2) Tender Pre Bid meeting: 20.03.2026 at 15:00 hrs at above mentioned office. 3) Last Date for Receipt of Tender: 25.03.2026 before 16:00 hrs. 4) Opening of Technical Bid: 26.03.2026 after 16:30 hrs. More details can be downloaded from website - <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/- Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, Bengaluru

DIPRI/CP/6296/CCL/2025-26

Coin used in T20 World Cup final auctioned for ₹26 lakh



Chennai Super Kings names Foster as the fielding coach for IPL 2026



Arundhati in race for ICC Women's Player-of-the-Month award



10-man Punjab FC plays out a draw with FC Goa in the ISL



Winning T20 World Cup biggest moment of my career: Samson

Dhoni offers a pragmatic advice to rookie Prashant

Shah urges long-term planning of India's sporting future

Sinner and Sabalenka secure titles

Humpy reconsidering Candidates trip due to the West Asia conflict

16-year-old Mayank ends North-East's long wait for a GM

Mishra said: "Mayank's journey to becoming a GM is truly the result of many years of hard work, dedication, and strong support from his family. It has been very satisfying to watch his progress – from a young and talented child to a mature, strong, and determined player."

Milan gives Inter Scudetto reprieve, Como eyes Champions League

The results: Serie A: Como 2 (Douvakis 59, Carlos 79) bt Roma 1 (Malen 7-pen); Lazio 1 (Isaksen 26) bt AC Milan 0; Pisa 3 (Moreo 9-pen, Caracciolo 52, 54) bt Cagliari 1 (Pavoletti 67); Sassuolo 0 lost to Bologna 1 (Dallinga 6); Verona 0 lost to Genoa 2 (Vitinha 61, Ostigard 86).

Bundesliga: Stuttgart 1 (Undav 56) bt RB Leipzig 0; Freiburg 0 lost to Union Berlin 1 (Woo-yeong 90+2); Werder Bremen 0 lost to Mainz 2 (Nebel 5, Jae-sung 52).

INBRIEF



Volumes of *Classic Cricketers of Tamil Nadu* released

Four volumes (10 to 13) of the *Classic Cricketers of Tamil Nadu* book were released by former TN player A.G. Satwender Singh and Chennai Super Kings CEO K.S. Viswanathan at a meet-and-greet function at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium in Chennai on Sunday. The book is authored by S. Varadharajan, a former club cricketer from TN. The book, whose first nine volumes were released last year, chronicles Tamil Nadu cricket between the 1972-73 and 1991-92 seasons. “This (writing a book) is one way of giving it back to the game which has given me a good life,” said Varadharajan.

Sodhi to miss remainder of T20I series against SA

Veteran New Zealand leg-spinner Ish Sodhi has been ruled out of the remainder of the T20I series against South Africa with a broken thumb. He was hit on the thumb during nets on the eve of the opener in Mount Maunganui on Saturday.

Young outduels Fitzpatrick to win Players Championship

Cameron Young outdueled England’s Matt Fitzpatrick down the stretch to fire a four-under-par 68 and claim a one-shot victory at The Players Championship golf in Miami on Sunday. The 28-year-old from New York pocketed the biggest PGA Tour win of his career after rattling in five birdies and a bogey in his final round.

Laporta re-elected FC Barcelona president

Joan Laporta was re-elected president of FC Barcelona for another five years after winning a leadership vote among members of the Spanish football powerhouse on Sunday.



Djokovic withdraws from the Miami Open

Novak Djokovic has withdrawn from the Miami Open with a right shoulder injury, organisers said on Sunday. He reached the fourth round at Indian Wells this week. He played with a compression sleeve on his right arm, telling Tennis Channel he was dealing with a forearm injury that was intermittently affecting his serve.

Decks cleared for Chinnaswamy Stadium to host IPL matches

authorities had announced the fixtures for the first phase (March 28 to April 12), taking into account the fact that the conduct of matches in the Garden City was subject to approval from the government.

A thorough inspection, including a mock drill, was carried out on Friday to assess the stadium’s preparedness and the final clearance was granted on Monday based on the recommendations of the committee.

This means that the IPL opener between RCB and Sunrisers Hyderabad will be held at Chinnaswamy on March 28, and so will one playoff match and the grand final towards the end of May.

Last Wednesday, the IPL

English sides seek redemption from Champions League reality check

Man City, Chelsea and Tottenham have seemingly difficult tasks as they trail by three goals against Real, PSG and Atletico respectively

FOOTBALL

Agence France-Presse
MANCHESTER

Kings of the league phase, England’s six Champions League sides were made to look like paupers in the first legs of the last 16 as they failed to muster a win between them.

Manchester City, Chelsea and Tottenham have seemingly insurmountable mountains to climb, even with home advantage this week, as they trail by three goals against Real Madrid, Paris Saint-Germain and Atletico Madrid respectively.

Liverpool and Arsenal will expect to still get past Galatasaray and Bayer Leverkusen, while Newcastle is dreaming of shocking



Better placed: Arsenal, which eked out a draw against Leverkusen, will be expected to win at home and progress. REUTERS

Barcelona in the Camp Nou after outplaying the Spanish champion in a 1-1 draw at St. James’ Park.

But after unprecedented domination of the early stages of the competition, AFP Sport looks at the rea-

sons behind a reality check for the Premier League’s best.

The Premier League’s fi-

nancial advantage over Europe’s other major leagues, thanks to far more lucrative television rights deals, has not been reflected in the latter stages of the Champions League for some time.

Only three of the last 13 Champions League winners have come from England.

Arsenal was the only Premier League club to reach the last four last season and none reached the semifinals in the 2023/24 campaign.

Fatigue Fatigue after a gruelling winter schedule is often cited as the main factor for the decline of English sides as the only major league without a winter break and two domestic cup competitions.

French great and form-

er UEFA president Michel Platini once referred to English sides as “lions in winter, lambs in spring”.

“In general, I think it is not helpful for English clubs not to have a winter break,” said Liverpool boss Arne Slot.

Of the six English sides involved in the Champions League, four of them also made the League Cup semifinals and five were involved in FA Cup action in the days before their European disappointment last week.

The fixtures:
Tuesday: Sporting vs Bodo/Glimt (11.15 p.m.); Chelsea vs PSG, Man City vs Real Madrid, Arsenal vs Bayern Leverkusen (1.30 a.m., Wednesday).
Wednesday: Barcelona vs Newcastle (11.15 p.m.); Tottenham vs Atletico Madrid, Liverpool vs Galatasaray, Bayern vs Atalanta (1.30 a.m., Thursday).

AROUND THE CITY

Big win for KSR (Thiruchengode)

Prakash Sugumar (four for 10) and E. Anbu Mani (four for 15) helped KSR (Thiruchengode) record a nine-wicket win over MVIT (Puducherry) in a men’s Pool-A match of the 12th Pavit Singh Nayar Memorial T20 all-India inter-collegiate tournament on Monday. M. Kishore Kumar made 97 as Kongu Arts & Science (Erode) outplayed Pillai College (Mumbai) by 98 runs in a Pool-B match. Chennai Super Kings players Prashant Veer, Kartik Sharma, and Gurjapneet Singh inaugurated the tournament.

The scores: Men: Pool-A: A.M. Jain 136 in 19.5 overs (V.S. Karthick Manikandan 4/16) lost to Guru Nanak 137/4 in 14.4 overs (L.R. Navin 71); MVIT, Puducherry 87 in 15.2 overs (Prakash Sugumar 4/10, E. Anbu Mani 4/15) lost to KSR, Thiruchengode 88/1 in 7.1 overs (V.S. Anovankar 37). **Pool-B:** Pachaiyappa’s 168/9 in 20 overs (E. Bharathiraja 33, R. Dhanush 35, G. Bala 48, G. Arul Suba 4/25) bt SMVEC, Puducherry 91 in 17 overs (R. Dhanush 4/11). Kongu Arts & Science, Erode 192/3 in 20 overs (M. Kishore Kumar 97, R. Vikram Ravand 67) bt Pillai College, Mumbai 94 in 15.5 overs (Aum Kadam 30, M. Manoj Rajan 4/12, K. Yogeshwaran 3/23). **Pool-C:** KPR College, Coimbatore 165/6 in 20 overs (R. Sree Ramesh

36, S. Sabari Sandy 48, V. Jai Balaji 31, Aravindhan 3/29) bt Guru Nanak-B 164 in 20 overs (Anirudh Krishnan 60, S. Sachin Sreedev 30, S.J. Arunkumar 4/16, A. Amit 4/33). Gobi Arts & Science 155/7 in 20 overs (G. Navin 34, S.P. Ragul Rithick 35, B. Sachin 32) tied with RKM Vivekananda 155/9 in 20 overs (Abhinav Kannan 54, Shubhang Mishra 34, S.N. Jeeva 3/43) (RKM won in the Super Over). **Pool-D:** Sri Ramakrishna CAS, Coimbatore 191/6 in 20 overs (G. Ajitesh 74, B.M. Prasanna 35, K. Chandru 31 n.o., Siddhesh Salunke 3/38) bt CKT College, Mumbai 93 in 19.5 overs (M. Pranesh 3/18). TKR, Hyderabad 184/3 in 20 overs (P. Aryan Raj 47, Aryan Krishna 83 n.o., S. Rohith Reddy 46) lost to Loyola 188/5 in 16.4 overs (P.L. Harshavardhan Sai 94). **Women:** Queen Mary’s 121/7 in 20 overs (B. Madhumitha 3/18) lost to DKM, Vellore 124/9 in 18.2 overs. VET, Erode 98/7 in 20 overs lost to KSR, Thiruchengode 100/3 in 18.4 overs (B. Deepika 31 n.o.) JBAS 182/4 in 20 overs (N. Asin 46, M. Uma Maheswari 43 n.o.) bt SSS Jain 70/6 in 20 overs (S. Pravitha 3/6).

Krishnan-Balaraman pair triumphs

V. Krishnan and B. Balaraman secured 68.45% to win the Madras Race Club open bridge tournament. The pair of R. Sreekrishnan and N. Periasamy finished runner-up with 64.80%.



Happy bunch: The North Zone Squad celebrates its triumph. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Unbeaten North Zone claims J.K. Bose cricket title

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

North Zone won the J.K. Bose inter-zonal T20 tournament after another emphatic win against East Zone at the Roshanara Cricket Ground on Monday. The tournament was held as part of the Golden Jubilee edition of the Sports Journalists Federation of India (SJFI) national convention in the national capital.

North sealed the title by stitching together an unbeaten run in the competition. On Monday, North chased down 136 in 9.5 ov-

ers. Rishabh Singh smashed an unbeaten 87, and finished with 289 runs in the competition. In the other match, West defeated South by 10 wickets.

SJAM-1 paddlers reign Meanwhile, Sports Journalists Association of Mumbai (SJAM-1) emerged champion in the team event of the A.C. Ball Table Tennis Tournament.

SJAM-1 defeated the Delhi Sports Journalists Association (DSJA-1) in the final. The winning SJAM-1 team comprised Amol Karhadkar and Ashwin Ferro while DSJA-1, represented

by Bharat Sharma, Kushan Sarkar and Norris Pritam, finished runner-up.

Karhadkar also enjoyed a successful outing in the individual event. He won the men’s singles title, finishing ahead of K. Keerthivasan of the Tamil Nadu Sports Journalists Association.

The scores: East 135/6 in 20 overs (Pranab Shil 47 n.o., Abhishek 39 n.o.) lost to North 136/0 in 9.5 overs (Rishabh Singh 87 n.o., Akash Rawal 31 n.o.). South 97 in 18.5 overs (V.L. Sashank 34, Deep Sudhakar 4/13, Taus Rizvi 3/13) lost to West 98/0 in 13 overs (Taus Rizvi 53 n.o., Devendra Pandey 36 n.o.).

Espionage takes the honours in Time And Place Plate

RACING

HYDERABAD: Trainer D. Netto’s ward Espionage, ridden by Kuldeep Singh Sr., claimed the Time And Place Plate, the main event of Monday’s (Mar. 16) races here.

1. OWN OPINION PLATE (1,200M): SPECIAL STAR (Ajay Kumar) 1, La Fleuriere (Trevor) 2, Daring Spirit (P. Sai K) 3 and Zindabad (Santosh Raj) 4. Not run: Beverley and Star Councilor. 3/4, 1/2 and 2-1/4. Im, 13.46s. ₹36 (w), 10, 17 and 103 (p). SHP: 32, THP: 232, FP: 126, Q: 46, Tanala: 2,177. Favourite: Double Bubble. Owners: M/s. Ashok Ranpise, Seshadri Reddy Pochana, Teegala Vijender Reddy, Teegala Sumant Reddy, Teja Gollapudi, Bollineni Krishnaiah, Mukund Kakani, Pochana Arjun Reddy & Capt. Jamshed J. Appoo. Trainer: K.S.V. Prasad Raju.

NOTE: A stewards’ enquiry was conducted into the running of this race. It was observed that while negotiating the bend, Kitsune (Afroz Khan up) shifted in sharply and caused interference to Double Bubble (Sonu Kumar astride), resulting in the latter suffering a fall. Sonu, however, was reported to be out of danger. After examining the race replay and interviewing Afroz, the Stewards decided to disqualify Kitsune.

2. ELUSIVE HERO PLATE (1,400M): CERTAINTY (Kuldeep Singh Sr.) 1, Corté Madera (Suraj Narredu) 2,

Mystical Dawn (P. Ajeeth K) 3 and Misty Night (Akshay K) 4. 1, 3 and 1-1/4. Im, 25.97s. ₹66 (w), 11, 10 and 19 (p). SHP: 27, THP: 21, FP: 109, Q: 34, Tanala: 257. Favourite: Corté Madera. Owner: Mr. S. Pathy. Trainer: Laxman Singh.

3. DEMOCRACY PLATE (1,600M): REAL THALAIIVA (Dhanu S. Deora) 1, Whistledown (P. Ajeeth K) 2, Arizona Sun (Akshay K) 3 and Cape May (Suraj Narredu) 4. 3, 3-3/4 and 3. Im, 40.28s. ₹93 (w), 14, 10 and 12 (p). SHP: 32, THP: 52, FP: 907, Q: 314, Tanala: 2,200. Favourite: Cape May. Owner: Mr. Vin pin Kalra. Trainer: Jasbir Singh.

4. ARMAGNAC PLATE (1,200M): DECCAN SPIRIT (Dhanu S. Deora) 1, Tootsie Darling (P. Ajeeth K) 2, Warwick (Afroz K) 3 and Mexican Wave (Rafique Sk) 4. 3/4, 3/4 and 3-1/4. Im, 12.53s. ₹17 (w), 34, 11 and 39 (p). SHP: 40, THP: 80, FP: 609, Q: 130, Tanala: 4,742. Favourite: Tootsie Darling. Owners: Mr. Shailendra Singh & Mr. K. Ram Gopal Rao. Trainer: Magan Singh.

5. HIMALAYA PLATE (1,400M): MADANTÉ (Akshay Kumar) 1, Gold Touch (Kuldeep S.) 2, Grit ‘N’ Grace (Mukesh K) 3 and Northern Sky (Antony Raj) 4. 4-3/4, 3/4 and 3/4. Im, 25.04s. ₹49 (w), 12, 43 and 12 (p). SHP: 114, THP: 38, FP: 1,633, Q: 585, Tanala: 5,911. Favourite: Grit N Grace. Owner: M/s. Gallop & Grace LLP. Trainer: L.V.R. Deshmukh.

6. TIME AND PLACE PLATE (1,400M): ESPIONAGE (Kuldeep Singh Sr.) 1, Nonpariel (Mukesh K) 2, Diablo (Ajay K) 3 and One N

Only (P. Sai K) 4. 1-1/4, 3/4 and Neck. Im, 24.60s. ₹55 (w), 18, 13 and 33 (p). SHP: 34, THP: 69, FP: 207, Q: 77, Tanala: 1,915. Favourite: Nonpariel. Owners: M/s. Prakash Babu, P. Ranga Raju, Donald Anthony Netto & Tripuranenivenkata Aditya Chowdary. Trainer: D. Netto.

7. BLOOMER PLATE (1,200M): NATU NATU (Ajay Kumar) 1, Decan Ranger (Akshay K) 2, Battle On (Md. Ismail) 3 and Niloufer The Great (Afroz K) 4. 1-1/4, 6 and Neck. Im, 14.08s. ₹49 (w), 37, 14 and 17 (p). SHP: 29, THP: 84, FP: 204, Q: 85, Tanala: 737. Favourite: Deccan Ranger. Owners: Mrs. Shobana Kamineni, Ms. Anusala Kamineni & Mr. Paunsh Kamineni. Trainer: Laxman Singh. Jackpot: 70%; ₹3, 79, 330 (c/f) & 30%; 27, 095 (6 tkts.). Mini jackpot: (i) 49, 445 (c/o), (ii) 1,48, 822 (1 tkt). Treble: (i) 14,585 (1 tkt.), (ii) 3,575 (18 tkts.).

LIVE TELECAST

New Zealand vs South Africa: 2nd T20I, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 11.45 a.m.

IFL: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 4 p.m.

Champions League: Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LIV, 11.15 p.m. & 1.30 a.m. (Wednesday)

Brooklyn Beauty for feature event

HYDERABAD: The seven-year-old mare Brooklyn Beauty, who ran second in her last start, should make amends in the upper division of the Onnu Onnu Plate, the feature event of Tuesday’s (Mar. 16) races.

1. NARAYANPET PLATE (DIV. I) (1,100m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 3.00 p.m.: 1. Divine Connection (2) Abhay Singh 60, 2. Blissful (9) Md. Ekram 59, 3. Windsor (8) Surya Prakash 57.5, 4. Diligence (3) Kuldeep Sr. 55.5, 5. La Quinta (4) Suraj Narredu 55.5, 6. Red Hot Punch (5) P. Ajeeth K 54.5, 7. Feel The Magic (10) D.S. Deora 52.5, 8. Fox Worth (6) P. Sai K 52.5, 9. Fortune Art (1) H.M. Akshay 52, 10. Atreya (7) B. Nikhil 51, 11. Golden Aura (12) Afroz K 51, 12. Marissa (11) Uday Kiran 51 and 13. Timeless Elegance (13) G. Nareesh 51.

1. LA QUINTA,
2. FEEL THE MAGIC,
3. RED HOT PUNCH

2. FLIRTING VISION PLATE (1,200m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 3.35 p.m.: 1. Crimson Rose (5) B. Nikhil 60, 2. Inderdhanush (6) Rafique Sk. 60, 3. Knotty Senorita (8) P. Sai K 60, 4. Star Medat (2) Abhay Singh 58.5, 5. Assured Success (4) I. Chisty 58, 6. Silver Lining (12) Mohit 56, 7. Dream To Fly (1) G. Nareesh 55.5, 8. Glimmer Of Hope (11) Sonu K 55.5, 9. Quality Warrior (9) Md. Ismail 55.5, 10. Smart Boy (10) B.R. Kumar 55, 11. Taaliyah (3) Surya Prakash 55, 12. N.R.I. Range (14) Afroz K 54.5, 13. Aos Si (7) Santosh Raj 52 and 14. Blazing Saddle (13) Ajay K 51.5.

1. DREAM TO FLY,
2. SMART BOY,
3. N.R.I. RANGE

3. ONNU ONNU PLATE (DIV. I) (1,400m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 60 to 85, 4.05: 1. Brooklyn Beauty (9) Sonu K 60, 2. Decoy (12) Mukesh K 59.5, 3. Maverick (5) Kuldeep Sr. 58, 4. Kingston (2) Abhay Singh 56.5, 5. N.R.I. Sport (8) H.M. Akshay 55.5, 6. Runlikethewind (13) G. Nareesh 55.5, 7. Romantic Grey (11) Afroz K 55, 8. Star Forever (9) Vyasa (3) Ashad Asbar 54.5, 10. Dyanoosh (6) Surya Prakash 54, 11. Best Buddy (10) Md. Ekram 53, 12. Leather Back (7) Rafique Sk. 53, 13. Lucky Zone (4) P. Ajeeth K 53 and 14. Pacific Heights (1) Ajay K 53.

1. BROOKLYN BEAUTY, 2. DECOY,
3. VYASA

4. MOSSY BANK PLATE (1,400m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 4.35: 1. Bholi Punjaban (8) Mohit 60, 2. Clara (5) I. Chisty 59.5, 3. Rival (14) Suraj Narredu 56.5, 4. Bhairava (10) P. Ajeeth K 56, 5. Fly Tothe Stars (9) Ashad Asbar 55, 6. Rolls Royce (11) Abhay Singh 55, 7. Top In Class (1) Md. Ismail 55, 8. Clefairy (13) P. Sai K 54, 9. Hoping Star (7) D.S. Deora 52.5, 10. Just Incredible (3) Rafique Sk. 52.5, 11. Normui (2) B.R. Kumar 52, 12. Only The Brave (12) Uday Kiran 52, 13. Great Greiv (6) Surya Prakash 51.5 and 14. Sopranos (4) B. Nikhil 51.

1. BHAIRAVA, 2. RIVAL,
3. CLEFAIRY

5. HYDERABAD PLATE (1,100m), (Terms) Maiden, 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 5.05: 1. Divine Tiger (4) P. Ajeeth K 56, 2. Fugo (5) Trevor 56, 3. Knotty Circuit (9) P. Sai K 56, 4. Noble Bella (–), 5. Sporting Touch (7) Ashad Asbar 56, 6. Varttaman (2) Kuldeep Sr. 56, 7. You Tuber (1) Abhay Singh 56, 8. Anemara (3) B.R. Kumar 54.5, 9. Khamagani

(6) B. Nikhil 54.5, 10. My Day (8) Rafique Sk. 54.5 and 11. Veera’s Lakshmi (10) Md. Ismail 54.5.

1. FUGO, 2. DIVINE TIGER,
3. KNOTTY CIRCUIT

6. ONNU ONNU ONNU PLATE (DIV. II) (1,400m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 60 to 85 (Cat. II), 5.35: 1. Cherie Chevalier (13) Antony Raj 60, 2. Hurricane Bay (1) Afroz K 58, 3. Encore (14) Md. Ekram 56.5, 4. Calistoga (5) Ajay K 56, 5. Northern Waves (8) Suraj Narredu 55.5, 6. Arabeska (9) Akshay K 55, 7. Dapper Look (3) Abhay Singh 55, 8. Secret Saint (6) Trevor 55, 9. Baissa (11) G. Nareesh 54, 10. Kings Best (12) P. Sai K 54, 11. Noble Heart (10) Kuldeep Sr. 54, 12. Glorious Power (4) Santosh Raj 53.5, 13. Shadow Fax (2) H.M. Akshay 53.5 and 14. Torchbearer (7) P. Ajeeth K 52.5.

1. CHERIE CHEVALIER, 2. NORTHERN WAVES, 3. SECRET SAINT

7. NARAYANPET PLATE (DIV. II) (1,100m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 6.05: 1. Authoritarian (2) Ajay K 60, 2. Catchme If You Can (4) D.S. Deora 60, 3. American Flame (5) H.M. Akshay 57, 4. Lights On (7) Abhay Singh 57, 5. Trust Me (1) G. Nareesh 57, 6. Victory Run (10) Surya Prakash 54, 7. Ek (3) Afroz K 53.5, 8. My Honey (11) Kuldeep Sr. 53.5, 9. Faizah (6) Ashad Asbar 52.5, 10. Don Cherie (16) Md. Ekram 52, 11. Shreshththa (9) B. Nikhil 52 and 12. Most Beautiful (12) Uday Kiran 51.

1. AUTHORITARIAN, 2. VICTORY RUN, 3. EK

Day’s best: LA QUINTA Jackpot: 2, 3, 4, 6 & 7. Mini jackpot: (i) 1, 2, 3 & 4, (ii) 4, 5, 6 & 7. Treble: (i) 2, 3 & 4, (ii) 5, 6 & 7. Tanala: All races.

My target is to be in the top-30

After back-to-back titles in Thailand and Azerbaijan, the 20-year-old heads to the Orleans Masters in France looking to establish herself on the international badminton circuit



K.V.S. GIRI

INTERVIEW

Devika Sihag

Devvanshi Bihani

What began from the recreational courts of Panchkula has now taken Devika Sihag to the podium on the BWF circuit.

Her recent breakthrough performances at back-to-back tournaments in Thailand (a Super 300 event) and Azerbaijan, where she clinched the title, signal a promising phase in her young career and point to the emergence of a new offensive presence in Indian badminton.

She will next be in action at the Orleans Masters in France, beginning March 17 (Tuesday), as she looks to build on her recent run of form.

Hailing from Haryana, the same State that produced Olympian Saina Nehwal, the 5'9" shuttler literally stands tall with a frame that invites comparison with another Olympian P.V. Sindhu.

However, her ascent has not been without its structural and physical taxes. Battling the knee issues with her patella (the bone in front of the knee) inherent to tall athletes and overcoming the psychological complex of facing compatriots, Devika has been honing her game in the high performance environment of the Prakash Padukone Badminton Academy (PPBA) in Bengaluru since 2018.

Training alongside Olympic pedigree and balancing a degree in Sports Management, the 20-year-old, is now deep into her preparations for the top tier.

In a conversation with *The Hindu*, Devika spoke about the tactical shifts behind her recent success, the influence of being a sparring partner to Sindhu, and her early experiences on the senior circuit. Excerpts:

Can you take me back to the very beginning? How were you introduced to badminton?

My father used to go to Tau Devi Lal Stadium in Panchkula just for his fitness and running. He thought he would put me and my younger brother in badminton just for an evening hobby.

At first, it was just like that, but after some time, I started playing well and performed well at the State and National level. Then my parents thought that I could pursue it professionally.

At what point in your childhood did you realise you had to leave home to train professionally?

I didn't think about that. My coach suggested that now the level has increased, it is better to go there. I was 14 or 15 years old.

He convinced my parents and they talked with each other. That's how it was decided. The first two weeks were very difficult; I was homesick. But later on, it became better. But I still miss them sometimes.

There was some hesitation from your father about you moving to Bengaluru, and your mother had to convince him...

My father was convinced, but he felt I had to focus on my studies as well, so it would be difficult if I moved. But he

knew it was important for me, so he agreed. Now, I have almost finished my studies.

I am in my final year of graduation, pursuing BBA in Sports Management from Chitkara University. I mostly study on my own, so it is manageable.

Who was your earliest coach in Panchkula, and who are you training with now?

My earliest coach in Panchkula was Rohit Mandhan. Currently, I am training with coach Irwansyah (Adi Pratama). When I first came here, before Irwansyah, I was training under Mr. Umendra Rana.

I am also very grateful to my CBE team – Sagar sir (Sagar Chopda), (Umendra) Rana sir, Irwansyah, Sayali didi (Sayali Gokhale), and all the support staff. I also get financial support from Olympic Gold Quest (OGQ) and the Haryana Badminton Association (HBA). I am really thankful to them as well.

You're currently training in one of the best environments in India.

K. MURALI KUMAR



Who are the seniors or peers you train alongside, and how has watching their daily routine influenced your work ethic?

I have been training with Sindhu didi and Irwansyah for a few months now. It is a very good experience. She is a two-time Olympic medallist, so she knows what has to be done.

I watch her; she is very disciplined and does her work very meticulously. I have learned many things from her. She has good smashes and good footwork. I hope to learn more things from her.

You have a distinct advantage with your height compared to many other shuttlers, but of course, that comes with its own challenges. How did your coaches help you adapt your game to your frame?

My coaches always tell me that because of my height, I can play good back strokes. I can have good smashes and steep drops. So they have always made me work to improve that area.

I think tall players have a little bit of an advantage from the back, but it comes with consequences as well. Because of my height, I had knee pain for at least one year.

It was an on-and-off pain. I still get it, but it is not as bad as earlier. I've been doing my rehab and I consult my physios if I have pain.

Looking back at your training before the national set-up, what was your fitness regime like?

Where I used to train before, I didn't know about the scientific side. We didn't use to do much gym; we used to do light gym or just run and do on-court sessions. But here it was a balance of everything. I got to know the importance of the gym after coming here. So it helped me improve myself.

Tell us about your training schedule and diet?

We train around seven-eight hours in a day. We have half days on Wednesday and Saturday, and Sundays are off. In tournaments, I like Asian food, like ramen and Japanese food. At home, I mostly eat vegetarian food because my family is vegetarian. So I just eat what my mum makes.

With the increased travel, how are you managing the physical toll to stay injury-free?

It's really difficult. If we are travelling to two tournaments together, the time zone is really different. This happened to me in Thailand and Azerbaijan; there was a three-hour difference. So I just try to recover by eating good food and covering up my sleep.

Against Supanida Katethong at the Thailand Masters, you were praised for your composure and control at crucial moments. How difficult was it to stick to your game plan?

Before the match, I just thought that Supanida is really an attacking player and she is really fast on court. So I just thought I'll keep everything in. I will also attack, I won't go too much into defence, but I have to match her pace. That helped me.

You stated that in Thailand you stopped thinking about winning or losing. Was there a specific conversation that triggered this?

Irwansyah talked to me before the match. He just said that I don't have to worry too much. If we lose, we'll come back and train harder and work on our mistakes. I wouldn't say there was no pressure, but, my pressure was released a bit. So, I played calmly.

If you compare your game now to one year ago, what is the biggest mental or tactical shift you have made?

I would say that my speed is good; it has been better than before. Irwansyah has said that I have good strokes, but I have to work on my footwork and be faster on court. I can see that helping me in matches.

It has been better from before, and I can see that that is helping me as well in matches. So, I hope I can improve in that aspect more.

What are your targets for the next 12 months?

For this year, my target is to come in the top-30. I hope to get entries into Super 300 and 500 tournaments, and perform well in them.

TIT-Hyderabad app turns impaired speech into clear speech in near-real-time

While the current project runs in English, the team's next aim is to take these technologies to regional languages, like Hindi, Telugu, and Tamil, as many in India do not have the means to benefit from accessibility-focused AI models. For this work, Vineet Gandhi won the ANRF award in 2026

INTERVIEW

Vineet Gandhi

Divya Gandhi

A whisper. A few slurred words. For those who suffer from dysarthria, a motor speech disorder, basic communication is a challenge, indelibly affecting both their professional and personal life. But now a new innovation based on artificial intelligence (AI) and developed in India could be life-changing.

Led by associate professor Vineet Gandhi of the International Institute of Information Technology (IIIT), Hyderabad, a team has developed a simple app that can help people talk as an audio translation converts the speaker's voice almost in real-time. The app can either convert slurred speech into clear, natural-sounding speech or use a camera to analyse lip movements and subtle throat vibrations to generate intelligible speech.

While the current project runs in English, the team's next aim is to take these technologies to regional languages, including Hindi, Telugu, and Tamil, as many across the country do not have the means to benefit from accessibility-focused AI models. For this work, Mr. Gandhi won the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) award in 2026.

Excerpts from an interview:

What inspired you to begin work on this humanitarian AI project?

My research has always been driven by a simple question: what real problem can technology help solve?

While my academic training is primarily in computer vision, about four years ago, I began to see exciting possibilities emerging in speech research and decided to explore the field more deeply. I became increasingly aware of the challenges faced by many individuals who lose their ability to speak due to medical conditions: the impact of this loss extends far beyond communication – it affects independence, identity, and connection.

Recognising this need inspired me to focus my work on accessibility-driven technologies designed to restore or enable speech, with the goal of helping people regain their voice.

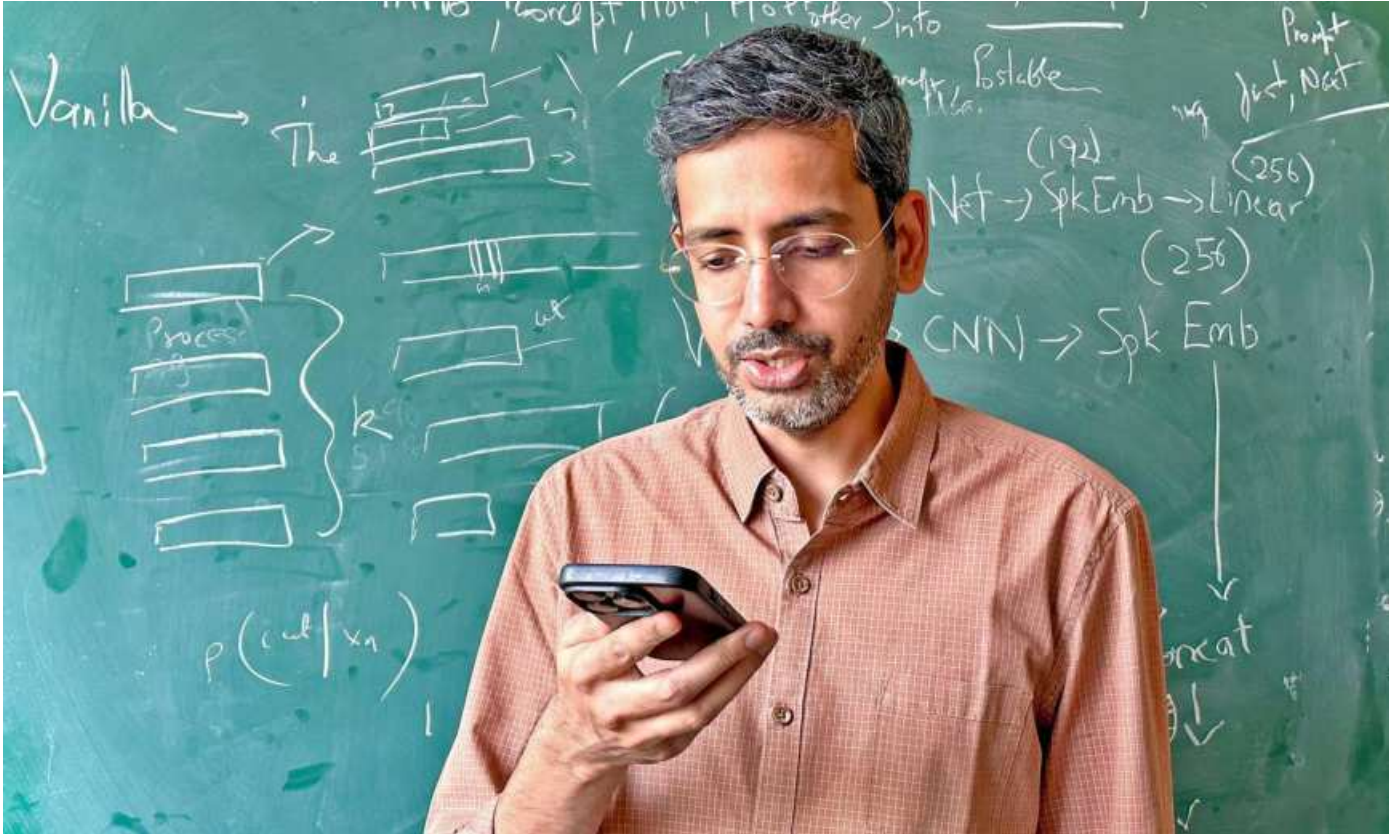
Could you describe how the app works for people with speech impairment?

The app is designed to convert impaired or distorted speech into clear, natural-sounding speech with only a few hundred milliseconds of delay. A user simply speaks in their own voice, and the system processes it to produce intelligible speech for the listener.

We are also developing a complementary lip-to-speech capability, where a person can silently move their lips and the system generates the corresponding speech.

A key aspect we are focusing on is personalisation, where users can calibrate and refine the application to their voice by reading few minutes of text on the app.

We aim for these technologies to be integrated into common communication platforms, such as web-based calling applications, making everyday communication



Speech alchemist: Vineet Gandhi of IIIT-Hyderabad, leader of the team that developed an app that converts slurred speech into clear speech or uses a camera to analyse lip movements and subtle throat vibrations to generate intelligible speech.

easier for people with speech impairments.

You also aim to expand this technology to regional Indian languages. How do you hope to achieve this?

At present, much of the global speech technology ecosystem is predominantly designed for English, and our initial experiments have naturally followed the same trajectory. However, a major goal of our research is to extend these capabilities to regional Indian languages, where accessible speech technologies are equally important.

To achieve this, we plan to collect speech data in Indian languages and develop data-efficient models suited for low-resource scenarios. Our approach includes data augmentation and efficient fine-tuning of pre-trained models.

We have already conducted preliminary experiments in Hindi with promising results, and with support from the Anusandhan National Research Foundation, we aim to further enhance and expand this work to additional Indian languages.

You believe that “accessibility and linguistic diversity” are crucial for AI research in India. Could you elaborate?

Accessibility and linguistic diversity are fundamental considerations for AI research in India. Having spent several years in Europe, I observed that accessibility is far more systematically integrated into public infrastructure and digital services there.

In contrast, India still has significant gaps, even in public spaces such as railway stations, where basic accessibility provisions are often limited. This highlights the broader need to design technologies that consciously include people with disabilities.

At the same time, India's linguistic diversity presents another important dimension. In many parts of the country, particularly in rural regions, speech remains the most natural and primary mode of interac-

tion. Text-heavy or typing-based interfaces may not always be practical or inclusive in such contexts. Therefore, AI systems designed for India must prioritise speech-based interaction and support multiple regional languages.

Taken together, meaningful accessibility and strong support for linguistic diversity are essential if digital technologies are to be truly inclusive and widely usable across the country.

WHO has said the “future of healthcare is digital”...

The World Health Organization has emphasised that the future of healthcare will be increasingly digital. In a country like India, telemedicine can play a transformative role, particularly when supported by basic diagnostic infrastructure at the local level, which enables more accurate remote consultations.

Another important direction is AI-assisted diagnostics, where machine learning systems analyse medical images, speech, or health records to support early disease detection and prediction.

Practical solutions are already emerging. For example, ‘Shishu Maapan’ developed by Wadhvani AI helps measure newborn weight and size simply from mobile photos and is being adopted by frontline health workers such as ASHA workers.

Digital tools are also enabling assistive healthcare technologies, including speech restoration systems for individuals who have lost their ability to speak, and wearable devices that continuously monitor health parameters and alert doctors to potential anomalies. These developments illustrate how digital innovation can make healthcare more accessible and scalable.

A common criticism of AI-generated speech is that while it’s intelligible, it often fails to capture the unique cadence of the speaker. When restoring a voice to someone with dysarthria, how do you balance the need for clear communication with the need to preserve the user’s

individual human essence?

This is an important concern. If recordings of the speaker's original voice from before the onset of dysarthria are available, modern voice cloning techniques can recreate that voice with as little as 10 seconds of speech. So preserving an individual's vocal identity is technically feasible today, and there is substantial research demonstrating this capability.

Our current app, however, focuses primarily on restoring content intelligibility, ensuring that what the user intends to say is conveyed clearly. For now, the generated speech uses a common voice rather than a personalised one.

That said, text-to-speech systems are becoming increasingly natural, to the point that they are now being integrated into conversational bots replacing many traditional customer service applications. Emotional nuance remains more challenging, as we discussed in our earlier work on empathic speech generation, but progress is rapid.

How does the model differentiate between impaired speech and a noisy background as the user navigates, say, a busy Indian street?

This is indeed a significant challenge in India, where real-world environments can be extremely chaotic. Anyone who has thought about deploying self-driving cars here quickly realises how unpredictable our roads can be: traffic patterns, honking, pedestrians, and vehicles all interacting in highly dynamic ways. Speech technology faces a similar level of complexity.

In our experiments, we improve robustness using noise augmentation, where we simulate different noisy environments during training so the model learns to handle background sounds.

Ultimately, the most effective solution is to collect and train on more real-world data from noisy settings. Even then, some performance degradation is inevitable because separating impaired speech from heavy background noise is fundamentally a difficult problem.

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Plumes of smoke rise from an oil facility in Fujairah, the UAE, on Saturday. AP

Environment: yet another casualty of the West Asia war

Agence France-Presse

From the jet fuel used in bombing raids to acrid smoke from burning oil depots, the conflict in West Asia is inflicting a significant toll on nature and the climate.

U.S. and Israeli aircraft use a considerable amount of fuel reaching the Gulf and flying sorties over Iran, said Benjamin Neimark at Queen Mary University of London.

Deploying stealth bombers and fighter jets around the clock adds a significant amount of planet-warming greenhouse gas emissions into the atmosphere.

“The U.S. Navy also has a significant fleet which will be operating remotely for some time,” Neimark said. “That is a significant number of U.S. troops that need to be fed, housed, and working around the clock. These floating cities all need energy.”

This is provided in part by diesel generators, even if most larger aircraft carriers are nuclear powered, an energy source that produces far less emissions than fossil fuels. But many experts take into account everything from the manufacture of weapons and explosives to post-war reconstruction efforts when

The Gaza conflict generated some 33 million tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent, an amount comparable to 7.6 million petrol-powered cars

estimating the total environmental impact of conflict.

According to one study published in the peer-reviewed journal *One Earth*, the Gaza conflict generated some 33 million tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent, an amount comparable to 7.6 million petrol-powered cars or the annual emissions of a small country like Jordan.

By one estimate, the war in Ukraine has caused more than 300 million tonnes of additional emissions, equivalent to France's annual output.

This estimate, by the Initiative on GHG Accounting of War, takes into account military operations and reconstruction efforts, forest fires, and longer flight routes.

This conflict is playing out on the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial artery for the passage of oil and gas supplies to global markets that depend on energy from the Gulf.

Ships transporting these highly flammable fuels through the narrow waterway, along with the region's oil and gas refineries and storage facilities, were “all a target” in this war, said Neimark.

“We have already seen a significant amount of refineries targeted. These toxic flames are deadly and have a severe climate cost.”

Since erupting on February 28, the conflict has sent oil prices soaring and focused fresh attention on the global transition to cleaner, more climate-friendly forms of energy.

Andreas Rudinger, from the Institute for Sustainable Development and International Relations, said the economic knock-on effects of the war had put policy makers “under pressure to reduce the burden on prices over climate action”. But there's also a “glass half-full perspective”, Rudinger said: “From a purely economic standpoint... rising fossil fuel prices make decarbonisation and electrification solutions more attractive,” he said.

He pointed to the rise in popularity of heat pumps in the aftermath of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, which caused energy prices in Europe to rise sharply.

Apart from climate concerns, strikes on energy infrastructure, oil tankers and military targets pollute the surrounding air and water and spread highly toxic chemicals far and wide, experts say.

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

A quiz on science films at the Oscars through history

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

Steven Spielberg directed X, a 1977 film about celestial phenomena and government research. It focused on the linguistic and mathematical challenges of communicating with extraterrestrial visitors using light and sound, culminating at a place called Devil's Tower. Name X.

QUESTION 2

Focusing on radio astronomy and the SETI program, this 1997 adaptation of a Carl Sagan novel explored how a dedicated scientist detected prime numbers transmitted from the Vega system and depicted voyage through a wormhole onboard a complex alien transport. Which film?

QUESTION 3

Which 1990 film nominated for the Oscar for Best Picture depicted neurologist Oliver

Sacks's clinical breakthrough of using a drug called L-DOPA to revive patients immobilised by encephalitis lethargica? The film explored the biochemistry of the human brain and the fleeting yet bittersweet nature of the drug.

QUESTION 4

This 1983 film focused on aeronautics and human physiology in extreme conditions in the course of dramatising the transition from supersonic flight to entering earth orbit. The story itself followed the seven pilots selected for Project Mercury, the U.S.'s first human spaceflight programme. Name the film.

QUESTION 5

When 12 monolithic vessels descend on places around the earth, a linguistics professor studies the aliens' semagrams to establish communication, exploring the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis and theoretical physics involving the perception of non-linear time. Name this cerebral masterpiece.



Visual: Name this late American visual effects supervisor known for his science-themed scenes in 2001: *A Space Odyssey*, *Blade Runner*, and *The Tree of Life*, among others. JULIAN HERZOG

Please send in your answers to science@thehindu.co.in

Answers to March 10 quiz:

1. Name of the terms denoting collective nouns for animals – **Ans: Venery**
 2. Primates that are together called a 'troop' or a 'congress' – **Ans: Baboons**
 3. Ominous birds of ill omen in the 15th century – **Ans: Ravens**
 4. Collective noun for rhinoceroses – **Ans: Crash**
 5. Collective noun for apes because they're mischievous – **Ans: Shrewdness**
- Visual: **Murmuration**

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For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Daily page'

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Estimated increase in global demand for LNG by 2040

54 in per cent. Global demand for liquefied natural gas is estimated to rise by 54-68% by 2040 and 45-85% by 2050, from 422 million metric tons in 2025, Shell, the world's biggest trader of LNG, said on Monday. A year ago, Shell said that global demand for the fuel was expected to rise between 630 million and 718 million metric tons a year by 2040. REUTERS

Number of child abuse cases reported in Pakistan in 2025

3,630 At least 3,630 child abuse cases were reported across Pakistan in 2025, marking an 8% increase from the year before that, according to data released by Sahil, a non-profit entity. It said that gender divide analysis shows that out of the total reported cases of child abuse, 1,924 (53%) of victims were girls. PTI

Flights cancelled by Indian airlines due to West Asia conflict

4,335 Union Civil Aviation Minister K. Rammohan Naidu on Monday informed the Rajya Sabha that Indian airlines have cancelled 4,335 flights and 1,187 flights by foreign carriers so far due to the West Asia conflict. The escalating conflict involving the U.S., Israel and Iran has significantly disrupted flight operations. PTI

Decrease in fire incidents in Punjab and Haryana

90 in per cent. Punjab and Haryana have collectively recorded a reduction of more than 90% in fire incidents during the paddy-harvesting season in 2025, compared to 2022, the government informed Parliament on Monday. The information was shared by Union Minister of State for Environment Kirti Vardhan Singh. PTI

Number of biodiversity management committees set up

2.76 in lakh. Biodiversity Management Committees have been established in India, strengthening community participation in biodiversity governance and benefit-sharing mechanisms, the first report on the implementation of the Nagoya Protocol has said. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why India must electrify its kitchens

Is electric cooking cheaper and more efficient than LPG for Indian households? Can induction cooktops handle the realities of everyday Indian cooking? Can smart technologies help flatten electricity peaks? What policy changes are needed for India to shift from LPG to electric kitchens?

EXPLAINER

Kalvan Mangalapalli

The story so far:

India spends \$26.4 billion a year importing cooking gas, most of it shipped through the Strait of Hormuz. It has 332 million LPG connections, yet 37% of households still burn firewood and dung. The arithmetic has shifted: cooking with electricity is now cheaper than cooking with unsubsidised LPG. But moving hundreds of millions of kitchens from flame to wire raises a chain of questions about cost, grid stress, and who pays when demand spikes.

Why is gas-based clean cooking hitting a wall?

Domestic LPG connections grew from 150 million in 2015 to 332 million by 2025, but India imports 60% of its LPG and 50% of its natural gas. The Institute for Energy Economics and Financial Analysis (IEEFA) estimates that the combined import bill reached \$26.4 billion in FY24-25 – a 50% jump in six years.

Every West Asian escalation sends a price shock straight into Indian kitchens. Gas-based clean cooking has hit an affordability ceiling.

Can electricity beat gas on cost, efficiency, and everyday cooking?

An IEEFA study from October 2025 found that electric cooking is 37% cheaper than non-subsidised LPG and 14% cheaper than piped natural gas for a family of four in Delhi – even without any electricity subsidy. Only the heavily subsidised Prime Minister Ujjwala Yojana (PMUY) pricing undercuts e-cooking, and that subsidy costs the exchequer thousands of crores each year.

The efficiency gap is equally stark. Induction cooktops transfer about 85% of their energy to the vessel, while an LPG burner manages roughly 40%. Electric pressure cookers, tested across the MECS programme's multi-country cooking diaries, use less energy than any other device assessed.

Indian cooking is not a single-pot affair. Anyone who makes chapatis, does a *tadka*, and stirs a *dal* simultaneously knows that a standard single-plate induction unit will not suffice.

The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI) argues that research and development on multi-pot and flame-replicating induction models is essential before mass adoption can take off, not as an afterthought, possibly explaining the 5% electric cooking share in 2021.

Both the International Institute for Sustainable Development and IEEFA recommend starting with urban kitchens, thereby freeing imported LPG for rural areas that still lack reliable electricity.

The logic is sound – but it leads to a harder question: if a hundred million urban kitchens switch on induction cooktops in the evening, what happens to the power grid?

What is a 'peak'?

Electricity demand shifts throughout the day. It ramps up around 3 p.m. and again from 9-11 p.m., mostly because households all flip on lights, fans, TVs, and ACs at the same time. This surge is called the 'peak.'

India's peak demand rose from 148 GW in 2014 to a record 242.5 GW in December 2025. According to the International Energy Agency (IEA), for every degree



GETTY IMAGES

rise in average daily temperature, peak demand now increases by more than 7 GW.

When demand spikes beyond a distribution company's (discom's) contracted supply, it has a few options – none of them cheap.

It can buy power on the spot market, typically through the Indian Energy Exchange, where prices can swing from ₹3.50 per unit in normal hours to ₹9-10 during peak slots. It can fire up expensive gas-based peaking plants or release stored hydropower. It can dispatch grid-scale batteries – BSES Rajdhani in Delhi has commissioned India's first commercial battery storage system for precisely this kind of energy arbitrage.

Or, as a last resort, it can impose planned power cuts, rotating blackouts across zones – what is known as load shedding – which disrupts livelihoods, damages industrial output, and is increasingly penalised by regulators.

Now imagine adding millions of induction cooktops to that evening peak window. Without intelligent management, mass electric cooking would steepen the evening peak, raise spot-market costs, and increase the risk of outages.

The question is not whether to electrify cooking, but how to do so without overwhelming the grid. That is where automated demand response enters the picture.

Can smart technology flatten the peak automatically?

OpenADR – Open Automated Demand Response – is a two-way communication standard that enables automated participation of smart thermostats, EV chargers, water heaters, and cooktops in demand response, ancillary services (frequency/voltage), and DER coordination. These devices can adjust their consumption automatically, without anyone having to lift a finger.

Born after California's 2002 energy crisis, its latest version plugs into modern

energy systems using standard web protocols.

India has begun deploying it. Tata Power Delhi Distribution ran the country's first OpenADR pilot across 167 commercial and industrial consumers, achieving an average peak reduction of 14%. A study done of the pilot stated that peak shaving ability of close to 7% could be achieved if the technology were deployed across buildings in India.

Internationally, South Korea's AutoDR pilot reduced electricity use by 24%; such programmes typically pay for themselves within four years by deferring the cost of new grid infrastructure.

What discoms still lack is the full stack: OpenADR-compliant servers, smart-meter-embedded receivers, and aggregator platforms that can orchestrate distributed loads into virtual power plants.

Building this stack is essential – but it is only half the solution. The other half lies in turning households from passive consumers into active grid participants, while also upgrading household load capacity from 3 kW to 5 kW through investment in transformers and feeder infrastructure.

Can rooftop solar and neighbourhood trading take the pressure off the grid?

A rooftop solar panel paired with a battery can turn a household into a 'prosumer' – both a producer and a consumer. The solar panel generates power by day; the battery stores surplus energy; and that stored energy can be used in the evening to run the induction cooktop. This offsets precisely the peak that mass e-cooking would otherwise create.

A 2025 Australian national-grid study referred to a halving of peak load and reduction of grid reinforcement costs by 75% when residential electrification was combined with rooftop solar, batteries, and off-peak scheduling.

India's rooftop solar capacity is

projected to more than double from 24 GW in 2026 to over 41 GW by 2030, boosted by the PM-Surya Ghar Yojana, which aims to provide 300 units of free electricity to 10 million households.

The real impact comes when surplus solar is not just stored but traded.

Peer-to-peer (P2P) energy trading allows households to sell excess electricity directly to neighbours through digital platforms, bypassing the traditional discom route.

India ran South Asia's first blockchain-based P2P solar trading pilot in Lucknow, led by the India Smart Grid Forum and Australia's Powerledger, under a regulatory sandbox approved by the Uttar Pradesh Electricity Regulatory Commission. Prosumers set prices, tracked trades in real time, and settled transactions through smart contracts. The result was a 43% reduction in the energy buy price compared with the retail tariff.

Following the pilot's success, Uttar Pradesh directed all its utilities to make provisions for P2P trading – a first for any State. In February 2026, the Centre announced a P2P facility under the India Energy Stack for Delhi and western Uttar Pradesh. If a cluster of homes on a single feeder can trade solar surpluses during the evening cooking hours, the local peak flattens, the discom avoids buying expensive exchange power, and the neighbourhood effectively becomes a micro virtual power plant.

What needs to happen, and how soon?

New York's All-Electric Buildings Act mandates that most new buildings under seven storeys be all-electric from January 2026, and taller buildings from 2029.

India has begun laying the groundwork. The Go Electric campaign and the National Efficient Cooking Programme target two million induction stoves. The Bureau of Energy Efficiency has launched star labelling for induction hobs; the PM-Surya Ghar scheme links rooftop solar adoption to household savings.

But a wider architecture is needed: redirect part of the estimated ₹40,000 crore annual LPG subsidy towards one-time capital support for induction cooktops. Expand Energy Efficiency Services Limited's (EESL) bulk-procurement model to e-cooking appliances. Mandate time-of-use tariffs for e-cooking and require OpenADR compatibility in new appliances and smart meters. Fund R&D on multi-pot induction technology designed for Indian cooking. And mandate all-electric construction for new residential buildings in Tier-1 cities.

The urgency is as much geopolitical as it is economic. Every dollar India spends on LPG imports goes through supply chains exposed to the Strait of Hormuz and the decisions of oil producers.

Electricity is different – you can generate it from solar panels on rooftops and store it in batteries we assemble here. We are talking about moving from imported fuel to power we generate ourselves. That is not just energy policy, that is sovereignty.

Urban India is the obvious place to start this shift. The grid works, smart meters are already rolling out, and rooftop solar pays for itself in cities. The technology is there. The numbers add up. We know how to manage the grid. The question is whether the policy framework will catch up before the next oil shock forces the issue.

(The author is an Energy and Emerging Technologies expert)

THE GIST

Electric cooking is now cheaper than unsubsidised LPG, but shifting hundreds of millions of kitchens from flame to wire raises questions about grid stress and peak demand.

Induction cooktops are far more efficient than LPG burners, yet mass adoption will require multi-pot appliances, smart demand response, and upgrades to distribution infrastructure.

Rooftop solar, batteries, and peer-to-peer energy trading could help flatten evening peaks and reduce India's dependence on imported LPG.

